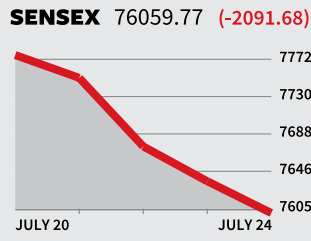


the hindu businessline



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23767.45	-566.85
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.48	-0.70
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.56	+0.28
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	143205.00	+2611
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	222721.00	+7247

QUANTUM.

Tata Steel explores pathway to reducing coke usage while retaining existing steel-making infrastructure p7



PULSE.

RG Kar and beyond: Hospital safety remains unfinished agenda p9

Nilekani to head task force on NTA reforms: PM

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the constitution of a high-power task force headed by technology expert Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms for the National Testing Agency (NTA), with a focus on overhauling the examination system through technology and structural changes.

The announcement comes amid sustained scrutiny of the NTA following a series of controversies over competitive examinations in recent years.

In a message on social media platform X, the PM said: “Friends, for the future of the students, the Indian government is taking many steps continuously. The people who played with the future of the students, they are rotting in the jails. We have already made a fast track court. We have to make sure that our exam procedures are transparent. With all these things in mind, under the leadership of the world-famous technology expert Nandan Nilekani, we have decided to form a high-power task force which will focus on examination reform.”

Details p10

Inflation remains RBI’s foremost priority: Governor

FOREX BOOST. Steps to attract foreign capital led to \$32 b inflows, largely via FCNR(B)

bl.exclusive

Raghuvir Srinivasan
K Ram Kumar
Maresh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said that inflation control remains the RBI’s foremost priority even as it remains mindful of growth risks.

He said the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) would continue to adopt a data-dependent approach while navigating the evolving growth-inflation trade-off.

“Our primary mandate is inflation and price stability. Therefore, we will do whatever is required first to keep price stability and then, to see to what extent we can support growth,” he said in an interview with *businessline* on Sunday.

While inflation has moved above the 4 per cent threshold, Malhotra indicated that policymakers do not yet see signs of broad-based price pressures becoming entrenched.

FCNR(B) BOOST

Meanwhile, the RBI’s recent



UMESH GOSWAMI

measures to attract foreign capital have garnered strong investor response, with banks mobilising nearly \$32 billion, largely through FCNR(B) deposits, while government securities have attracted more than \$7 billion in foreign inflows since the June policy measures, Malhotra said.

The Governor dismissed concerns that the inflows could represent a recycling of existing deposits. He added that the RBI had adequate tools to manage any resulting liquidity.

The Governor said the measures should be viewed in the context of challenging global conditions facing emerging markets and are

expected to further strengthen India’s balance of payments and currency stability.

RUPEE UNDERVALUED

Malhotra also sought to reassure markets on the rupee, arguing that recent depreciation does not reflect any weakness in the country’s economic fundamentals. According to him, pressure on the currency has largely stemmed from geopolitical tensions, dollar strength and broader volatility across emerging markets.

“I would like to reiterate that it would be reasonable to think that the rupee is not overvalued. If anything, one could argue that the rupee

has become undervalued both in nominal and in REER (real effective exchange rate) terms,” he said, adding that the RBI does not target any specific exchange rate or band for the rupee.

“Our intervention, whenever necessary, is targeted to curb excessive volatility,” he said.

He pointed to a current account surplus during April-May, robust services exports, resilient remittance inflows, rising merchandise exports and improving foreign direct investment flows as indicators of external sector strength.

Responding to concerns over the RBI bearing the hedging cost of fresh FCNR (B) deposits and offering concessional forex swaps for external commercial borrowings (ECBs) by public sector entities, Malhotra said: “It is not something which should be a matter of concern because we have a foolproof system of insuring ourselves. So, whatever dollars we get, the excess foreign currency is invested in foreign assets. The risk, therefore, is not there.”

Interview p3

Centre scraps ₹10,000-crore ATF fund after airlines skip MoU deadline

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Centre has discontinued its ₹10,000-crore aviation turbine fuel (ATF) Price Stabilisation Fund (PSF) scheme after no domestic airline came forward to sign the mandatory memorandum of understanding (MoU) with state-owned oil marketing companies within the prescribed timeframe, sources told *businessline*.

According to sources, the voluntary mechanism failed to take off despite the Centre operationalising the framework following the recent West Asia crisis.

“The scheme has been discontinued as no airline signed the required MoU with the OMCs within the prescribed timeline,” a person aware of the development said.

In June, the Cabinet approved the one-time ₹10,000 crore PSF to protect airlines from sharp volatility in global ATF prices triggered by the West Asia tensions.

INDUSTRY SUPPORT

The scheme was designed to compensate OMCs for losses arising from supplying jet fuel to participating airlines at a pre-determined benchmark price. Under the framework, participation by



GROUND. No domestic carrier signed the mandatory agreements with the OMCs within the prescribed timeframe

airlines was voluntary. Carriers choosing to opt in were required to execute a tripartite MoU with the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, and the concerned OMC before purchasing ATF under the fixed-price mechanism.

The benchmark ATF prices under the scheme were fixed at the free-on-board (FOB) level at ₹86.32 per litre for domestic operations and ₹104.49 per litre for international operations, with the effective selling price in Delhi working out to around ₹115 per litre after the applicable charges.

However, sources said the subsequent moderation in international crude oil and ATF prices significantly reduced the commercial attractiveness of the fixed-price mechanism.

As market-linked ATF prices eased following the de-escalation of tensions in West Asia, airlines preferred

to continue procuring fuel under the prevailing pricing mechanism rather than commit to the stabilisation framework.

WAR IMPACT

The PSF mechanism had replaced the temporary cap on domestic ATF prices that the government introduced after international jet fuel prices surged sharply during the height of the West Asia crisis.

Per sources, while the present scheme has been discontinued, the government remains prepared to consider similar market-stabilisation measures should global fuel prices witness another prolonged period of exceptional volatility.

“The framework was created to address an extraordinary situation. If similar circumstances arise again, the government has the experience and policy framework to respond quickly,” sources said.

Small truckers face a survival crisis amid rising costs and weak freight rates

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Ludhiana-based Roshan Singh Chawla, 52, owns three trucks — two Tata Prima heavy-duty trucks and an Ashok Leyland BOSS, which he purchased last Diwali. Trucking has supported his family for over two decades. But his sons have no plans to carry it forward.

Ritesh is in the final year of his BCom degree, while Arjun has just completed Class 12. Neither sees a future in the family transport business.

COST BURDEN

Finding drivers has become a struggle. When one fails to report, Chawla takes the wheel. Rising diesel prices, toll, insurance, loan repayments, maintenance and compliance costs leave little



Rising diesel prices, toll, insurance, loan repayments and maintenance costs leave little room for profit

room for profit. “We are only seeking a fair, viable and sustainable business environment,” Chawla said.

His predicament reflects a crisis among India’s transport operators. The All India Motor Transport Congress (AIMTC) said owner-drivers and micro-fleet operators, who move 70 per cent of domestic freight, are being squeezed by rising costs, stagnant freight rates, ex-

pensive finance and limited pricing power.

“If immediate corrective measures are not taken, thousands of small transport operators and self-driving truck owners will be forced to shut down, severely impacting India’s supply chain and economy,” said Bal Malkit Singh, adviser and former AIMTC President.

For decades, owning a truck offered a dependable livelihood. Today, diesel accounts for 55-60 per cent of operating costs, according to AIMTC, while toll, tyres, insurance, AdBlue, lubricants, maintenance, permits and compliance have all become more expensive.

More than three-fourths of India’s transport operators own five or fewer trucks, industry estimates suggest. Dependent on brokers and freight platforms, many ac-

cept low-paying loads to keep vehicles moving and to service loans.

SHORTAGE OF DRIVERS

The industry faces a shortage of 2.2 million commercial vehicle drivers. Long periods away from home, poor roadside amenities, unsafe parking and weak returns are discouraging younger workers. For owner-operators, the shortage means longer hours behind the wheel.

AIMTC has sought a review of mandatory vehicle-location tracking devices, citing installation costs and glitches in Vahan integration that delay fitness certificate renewals and permit approvals. It has urged the Centre and the States to rationalise toll, simplify compliance, improve highway facilities and link freight rates to operating costs.

Bhogapuram airport set to take flight on tribal beats

13,000 artistes from the Araku region to perform at the airport opening on August 1

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

When the new Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport opens at Bhogapuram, near Visakhapatnam, it will not just launch flights — it will also bring to the fore the rhythms of Andhra Pradesh’s indigenous culture.

Before the first commercial flight takes off, the tarmac will vibrate to the synchronised steps of 13,000 tribal dancers performing the ancient Dhimsa dance.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will formally inaugurate the greenfield airport, developed by the GMR Group, on August 1. He will also address a public meeting after the inauguration.

According to Andhra Pradesh Minister Kondapalli Srinivas, commercial operations at the airport will com-



Locals from tribal communities performing the Dhimsa dance in Bosubeda, near Araku Valley KR DEEPAK

mence on August 17. It is not just the inaugural festivities; the airport’s name also strikes an emotional chord with the locals.

Alluri Sitarama Raju was a celebrated revolutionary who united the tribal communities of the Manyam region and led the heroic ‘Rampa Rebellion’ against British colonial rule, eventually laying down his life for the cause.

According to an Andhra Pradesh Tourism Depart-

ment official, Dhimsa is the best-known cultural expression of the hill tribes of the Araku Valley. Typically performed by groups of 15- 20 women dressed in colourful traditional sarrees and ornaments, the dance features synchronised circular movements set to the rhythm of indigenous instruments played by male members of the community. These include the Mori, a wind instrument, and the Thudum and Dappu drums.

The synchronised movements reflect communal unity, friendship and the deep bond between tribal communities and nature, while the dance’s various forms portray worship, hunting, agriculture and everyday life.

Nearly 3 lakh people from Visakhapatnam, Vizianagaram, Srikakulam, Anakapalli and Parvathipuram Manyam districts are expected to attend the event. Around 5,000 buses will transport participants from 36 Assembly constituencies to the venue.

LED SCREENS

MT Krishna Babu, Chief Officer of the Airport Inauguration Committee, said an LED screen would be installed for every 5,000 attendees to enable the audience to watch the Prime Minister’s address.

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(CIN: L36911RJ1996PLC011381)				
Registered Office:- 19-A, Dhuleshwar Garden, Ajmer Road, Jaipur 302001, Rajasthan (INDIA)				
Tel : 0141-4110060, Website : www.au.bank.in, Email : investorrelations@aubank.in				
Statement of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026				
(₹ in Lakhs)				
S. No	Particulars	Quarter ended June 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	Quarter ended June 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	Year ended March 31, 2026 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	5,99,195.79	5,18,904.91	21,61,427.76
2	Net Profit for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	1,06,398.62	77,890.44	3,47,404.56
3	Net Profit for the period before tax (after Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	1,06,398.62	77,890.44	3,47,404.56
4	Net Profit for the period after tax (after Exceptional and Extraordinary items)	79,595.29	58,085.82	2,64,125.43
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax))	Refer Note (ii)	Refer Note (ii)	Refer Note (ii)
6	Equity Share Capital	74,897.20	74,519.30	74,826.71
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance sheet	19,22,525.49*	16,42,175.12**	19,22,525.49*
8	Securities Premium Account	5,57,991.87	5,36,390.07	5,54,034.57
9	Net worth (Refer Note iii)	20,52,031.68	17,43,653.06	19,62,694.85
10	Outstanding Debt	13,41,944.41	10,64,917.11	13,87,154.47
11	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio (Refer Note iii)	0.40	0.28	0.31
13	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) - ((before and after exceptional item) not annualised))			
	1. Basic (after exceptional item) (in ₹)	10.63	7.80	35.40
	2. Diluted (after exceptional item) (in ₹)	10.51	7.78	35.01
	3. Basic (before exceptional item) (in ₹)	10.63	7.80	35.40
	4. Diluted (before exceptional item) (in ₹)	10.51	7.78	35.01
14	Capital redemption reserve	-	-	-
15	Debenture redemption reserve	-	-	-

* As at March 31, 2026 ** As at March 31, 2025

- Notes:**
- (i) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter ended Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 & 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarter ended Financial Results are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com and of the Bank www.au.bank.in. The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below.
- (ii) Information related to the total comprehensive income and other comprehensive income are not furnished as Ind AS is not yet made applicable to Bank.
- (iii) Information as required pursuant to Regulation 52(4) of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 Methodology for computation of the ratios is as follows :

	Debt-Equity Ratio	Represents the Borrowings with residual maturity of more than one year/ Sum of Capital and Reserves & Surplus.
	Net worth	Calculated as per the Master Circular - Exposure Norms issued by the RBI.

Date : July 25, 2026

For AU Small Finance Bank Limited
Sanjay Agarwal
Managing Director and CEO

1800 1200 1200

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QUICKLY.

Work for commoners’ benefit, FM tells I-T dept

Mumbai: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman urged the Income Tax department to work for the benefit of the common people. She expressed disappointment at the laidback nature of government departments, which leads to illegal occupation or encroachments on government lands. Citing the challenges faced by the department in getting a nod to construct a building in Nariman Point, Sitharaman said these experiences, despite serving in the Indian Revenue Service, would have given them an idea of what the common man goes through. **PTI**

TN extends State Finance Commission’s tenure

Chennai: The Tamil Nadu government, by way of a gazette notification, has extended the tenure of the Seventh State Finance Commission by four months, until December 31, 2026. The Commission is tasked with examining the financial position of various urban and rural local bodies and making appropriate recommendations to the State government. Its tenure was originally scheduled to expire on August 31, 2026. The Seventh State Finance Commission is chaired by the retired IAS officer K Allaadin, and was formed in May 2025. **OUR BUREAU**

EPFO traces 1.18 lakh dormant accounts holding less than ₹1,000 for auto-refund

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Ministry of Labour and Employment has traced 1.18 lakh of the 7.11 lakh inactive Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) account holders eligible for automatic refunds of balances up to ₹1,000 lying unclaimed for years or even decades. Ministry sources told *businessline* that the EPFO has been able to authenticate 1.18 lakh subscribers’ individual account data with their active bank details. They described it as part of a pro-people step which began in 2014 when the Modi government came to power and introduced the scheme of providing a unique 12-digit account number for an EPFO subscriber, called Universal Account Number (UAN). The Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC), a Ministry of Electronics and Information

Russian supply disruption poses fresh risk to India’s crude imports

RISING UNCERTAINTY. Ukrainian attacks on key export infrastructure could inflate freight costs

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Crude oil imports in August face a fresh risk from Russia, with uncertainty mounting over crude loadings from the Black Sea port of Novorossiysk following Ukrainian attacks on key export infrastructure. The volume of imports during the month will also depend on the safe passage of Saudi Arabian barrels through the Bab el-Mandeb (BeM) strait. While refiners and traders do not expect an outright supply disruption, they warn that slower deliveries, higher freight costs and shrinking discounts on Russian crude could inflate India’s oil import bill, particularly at a time when the rupee remains weak against the US dollar. Russia has emerged as India’s largest crude supplier over the past three years, accounting for as much as 50 per cent of the country’s imports as refiners increasingly rely on discounted Urals crude because of the Western sanctions. Any disruption to these supplies, therefore, carries outsized implications for Indian refiners, many of whom have reconfigured their sourcing around Russian barrels. “As we speak, there are two developing scenarios important to track. First, crude oil (Urals grade) loadings from Novorossiysk port, considering the attacks by Ukraine on the Sheshkharis terminal. Besides, traders are not offering discounts for September loadings. So, barrels will be there, but there will be a price,” said a trade source.



STRATEGIC RELIANCE. Russia has emerged as India’s largest crude supplier over the past three years, accounting for as much as 50 per cent of the country’s imports **S REUTERS**

According to Kpler, the key uncertainty is whether Russian refiners, many of whom have reconfigured their sourcing around Russian barrels. “As we speak, there are two developing scenarios important to track. First, crude oil (Urals grade) loadings from Novorossiysk port, considering the attacks by Ukraine on the Sheshkharis terminal. Besides, traders are not offering discounts for September loadings. So, barrels will be there, but there will be a price,” said a trade source.

KEY UNCERTAINTY
According to Kpler, the key uncertainty is whether Rus-

sia can sustain export volumes amid continued Ukrainian attacks on its upstream and downstream infrastructure. Russia’s crude exports in July declined by around 4,00,000 barrels per day month-on-month. Sheshkharis, Russia’s largest crude export terminal, accounts for nearly 20 per cent of its seaborne crude shipments. The concern for India is less about physical availability than pricing. If Russian exporters trim discounts or shipments, Indian refiners will either have to pay more for Russian crude or replace

some of those barrels with costlier cargoes from other suppliers, pushing up procurement costs and the country’s import bill. The second variable is the continuing threat by Houthi rebels to Saudi Arabian crude exports transiting the Bab el-Mandeb strait. “The threat has already impacted supply from there. Although the Saudis are using Egypt’s Sidi Kerir terminal on the Mediterranean coast, it also increases costs,” the same source said. **ALTERNATIVE ROUTES** According to Equirus Securities, tankers can avoid the Bab el-Mandeb by taking alternative routes through the Suez Canal and the Mediterranean, but doing so could add nearly a month to voyage times. Longer journeys keep vessels tied up for extended periods, reduce tanker availability and significantly raise freight and insurance costs. Freight and insurance charges, which averaged \$4-5 per barrel before the conflict, have now climbed to \$13-15 per barrel. An official with a domestic refiner said the expectation

is that both Russian and Saudi barrels will continue to be available, but the logistics are becoming increasingly “tricky”. “Saudi Arabia usually supplies crude through VLCCs, but bypassing the traditional Red Sea route and exporting via Sidi Kerir adds to both voyage time and transportation costs,” the official said. Geopolitical tensions have already begun influencing global oil prices. According to S&P Global Commodity Insights, mounting concerns over disruptions to Red Sea shipping helped push Brent crude futures above \$100 per barrel on July 23. Kpler said that if Red Sea transit remains uninterrupted, Indian refiners will continue to have an important supply buffer through Saudi Arabia’s East-West pipeline to Yanbu, which recently supplied around 3,00,000-5,00,000 barrels per day of crude. “However, if the security situation deteriorates and Red Sea imports become unavailable during August, refiners will need to replace those barrels from alternative sources,” it said.

Amid slower growth trends, MTF book reaches ₹1.43 lakh cr



SHARP GROWTH. CareEdge said the MTF book had grown 11.1% in May from April, after a 1.6% rise in April **ANI**

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The industry’s margin trading facility (MTF) book touched a fresh high of ₹1,43,722 crore on July 22, as investor appetite for leveraged cash-market positions remains strong even as the pace of growth has slowed from earlier months. The latest figure was led by the NSE at ₹1,37,705 crore, while the BSE’s MTF book stood at ₹6,017 crore. In June, the industry ended with a record average MTF book of ₹1.36 lakh crore, up 7.1 per cent sequentially and 57.6 per cent year-on-year. The pace of growth slowed slightly to 5.1 per cent in July. CareEdge said the book had grown 11.1 per cent in May from April, after a 1.6 per cent rise in April.

AVERAGE TURNOVER Average daily turnover across equity and derivatives remained largely flat sequentially in June after a sharp run-up earlier this year, with higher securities transaction tax (STT) on derivatives, easing market volatility and cautious investor sentiment weighing on activity. The cash market turnover also softened after three consecutive months of growth, said CareEdge Ratings. “The MTF book crossing ₹1.4 lakh crore itself indicates that investor appetite remains strong. The moderation in growth during July is not a concern; after a sharp run-up over the last few

months, some cooling was always expected,” Ajay Garg, Director and CEO at SMC Global Securities said. “Investors are becoming more selective as valuations turn richer and markets witness intermittent volatility, which is a healthy sign rather than a negative one,” he said. **ROOM TO GROW** The segment still has room to grow as retail participation in equities deepens. “MTF has emerged as a useful financing tool for informed investors. We expect growth to continue, although at a more sustainable pace than what we have seen recently,” Garg said. Shripal Shah, MD & CEO at Kotak Securities, said the industry’s MTF book rise shows growing investor preference for regulated leverage through the cash market. “As activity in derivatives has moderated due to higher trading costs and regulatory changes, MTF has emerged as an attractive alternative for investors seeking leveraged exposure,” he said. Further, the wider availability of MTF on digital platforms has supported adoption. He also said the RBI’s revised funding norms for capital market intermediaries are aimed at funding structures and proprietary trading rather than retail participation. The long-term growth outlook for MTF remains intact due to rising investor adoption and its growing importance in brokers’ business models.

No mention of NEET protests in Mann Ki Baat

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday used his monthly *Mann Ki Baat* broadcast to spotlight India’s growing defence capabilities, space achievements, environmental conservation and grassroots success stories, while making no reference to the protests at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar or the controversy surrounding the NEET-UG paper leak. In an address coinciding with Kargil Vijay Diwas, Modi paid tribute to soldiers who fought in the 1999 Kargil War and said the country was honouring their sacrifice by building a stronger and more self-reliant defence ecosystem. He mentioned about the indigenously built missile system and said India’s defence exports and strategic partnerships are steadily expanding. “Whether it is defence production, defence exports or political cooperation with friendly nations — India is

continuously scaling new heights. Earlier this month, I was in Indonesia, where a major agreement regarding BrahMos and Astra missiles was concluded,” said the PM. **ENVIRONMENT & SPACE** He also focused on water conservation through the ‘Catch the Rain’ campaign, urging the people to participate in restoring ponds, wells and other traditional water bodies. On science and technology, Modi hailed the successful launch of Vikram-1, describing it as India’s first privately developed rocket and evidence of the gains from opening the space sector to private players. He also congratulated Indian students for their medal-winning performances at the international science Olympiads. Modi urged citizens to install eco-friendly clay idols during the upcoming Ganesh festival, and paid tribute to former President APJ Abdul Kalam ahead of his death anniversary.

Won’t contest 2028 polls, says Karnataka ex-CM Siddaramaiah

Press Trust of India
Bangaluru

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday announced that he will not contest the 2028 Assembly polls, citing advancing age and politics becoming “deeply polluted”. The Congress Working Committee member, however, asserted that he will remain active in politics. “Politics has become deeply polluted today, and for that reason I will not contest the 2028 Assembly elections. However, I will remain active in politics and continue to be a voice for the people’s hardships and well-being,” Siddaramaiah said in

a post on ‘X’, detailing what he said at a private event held on Saturday at KR Pet in Mandya district. Noting that the people of the Varuna constituency are urging him to contest the elections again, he said, “I have decided that I should not contest any more elections. Earlier, when I contested elections, it was the people of the constituency who supported us financially and ensured our victory. Today, that situation no longer exists.” “I am now 79-years-old. Our (Congress) government’s term has another year and a half remaining. By then, I will be 81-82 years old. I may not be able to work with the same energy and enthusiasm as before,” he said.

TODAY’S PICK.

KIMS (₹797.25): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of KIMS (Krishna Institute of Medical Sciences) has been in a long-term uptrend. But after hitting a record high of ₹858.15 on July 6, the price dropped. However, the stock is now hovering near the support at ₹780 where a rising trendline coincides. Moreover, the stock has formed a morning star candlestick pattern on the daily

chart. Hence, the indications are that the trend is turning bullish, and we are likely to see a fresh leg of rally from the current level. An upswing can lift the stock to ₹900. Traders can buy now at ₹797 and place stop-loss at ₹760. When the price hits ₹850, revise the stop-loss to ₹800. On a rally to ₹875, raise the stop-loss to ₹860. Book profits at ₹900. **Note:** The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

T+0 settlement rollout remains in limbo as brokers struggle with readiness

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The much-anticipated T+0 settlement proposal seems to have been put on the backburner after receiving three consecutive extensions amid resistance from brokers. Leading stock exchanges NSE and BSE launched the beta version of the T+0 settlement cycle in March 2024, even as the stock markets were operating on a T+1 settlement cycle. Subsequently, SEBI increased the number of scrips eligible for trading under the optional T+0 settlement cycle from 25 to the top 500 stocks by market capitalisation. **SEBI DEADLINE** However, brokers were not ready with the required systems to allow investors to trade under the T+0 settlement cycle because same-day settlement not only reduces their float income but also increases technology-related expenditure. The T+0 settlement cycle refers to a mechanism wherein the shares and money are credited to buyers and sellers on the day of the trade. Initially, SEBI set the deadline for rolling out the T+0 settlement cycle as May 1, 2025, and extended it to November 1, 2025, before

postponing it indefinitely. Last October, SEBI, in a circular, said, “Considering the challenges highlighted by qualified stock brokers in ensuring the timely readiness of systems... it has been decided to extend the timeline and the revised timeline will be communicated at a later date.” **LONG-TERM INVESTORS** Rajesh Singla, CEO and Fund Manager, Alpha AMC, said, “T+0 is a genuinely good idea, but brokers face multiple challenges, including running T+0 and T+1 settlements simultaneously for the same securities under the same ISIN. It creates operational complexity since most brokers simply have not built the back-end infrastructure required to handle this.” Broker infrastructure needs to be upgraded with SEBI support, potentially through incentives or mandatory implementation timelines, said Singla. Anand James, Chief Market Strategist, Geojit Investments, said a buyer in a T+0 transaction may not share the same enthusiasm as the seller in arranging funds on the same day, especially when T+1 is already running. Presently, there is hardly visible incentive to move towards T+0, especially for long-term investors.

TATA POWER
The Tata Power Company Limited
(Mundra Thermal Power Station - UMPP)
Tunda Vandi Road, Tunda Village, Mundra, Kutch, Gujarat
Reg. Office: Bombay House, 24 Horni Modi Street, Mumbai - 400 001

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

The Tata Power Company Limited hereby invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from eligible bidders for the following requirement for 4150 MW UMPP Mundra Thermal Power Station:

- Procurement of Horizontal Multistage Centrifugal Pump for Hydrojet System (Ref: 4100068676)
- Supply of Dozer Spares along with On-site Supervision Services for installation of supplied spares (Ref: 4100068657)
- Supply of Structural materials (Ref: 4100068752)
- Concrete Pre-cast Trench Cover Replacement work at Tata Power Mundra (Ref. 4100068886)

For prequalification requirements, tender fee, bid security etc., please visit Tender section of our website (**URL: https://www.tatapower.com/tender/tenders-listing**) and refer detailed Tender Notice for subject tender. Eligible bidders willing to participate in this tender may submit their Expression of Interest along with the Tender Fee latest by **03/08/2026**

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CIN - U24231KL1979PLC003112

SALE OF ASSETS OF THE CORPORATE DEBTOR BY WAY OF E-AUCTION

Notice is hereby given to the public that the undersigned, appointed as the Liquidator for M/s Vysali Pharmaceuticals Limited (In Liquidation) by the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Kochi Bench vide IA (IBC)/LIQ/6/KOB/2024, Order Dated 03-12-2024, will conduct the E-auction for the sale of the assets of the Corporate Debtor. The sale will be conducted on an "as is where is, as is what is" basis on the platform https://bbi.baanknet.com.

Auction Process: The process will proceed to the auction of assets in parcels listed below.

Asset	Reserve price (in Rs)	Earnest Money Deposit (in Rs)	Incremental Bid Amount (in Rs)
Asset 1: Land & Building at Edathala, Aluva east village; Land extent: 426.69 Cents Building: 51,145 Sq. Ft.	Rs. 13,36,68,963/-	Rs. 1,33,66,896/-	Rs. 10,00,000/-
Asset 2: Land & Building at Edappally, Edappally south village; Land extent: 64.59 Cents; Building: 17,722 Sq. Ft.	Rs. 6,56,74,925/-	Rs. 65,67,492/-	Rs. 10,00,000/-

Inspection Date: On or Before 25th August 2026, 5 PM
Date and Time of E-auction: 27th August 2026 (from 11 am to 1 pm)
Last Date for Submission of Tender Documents and EMD Amount: on or before 26th August 2026, 11 am

For detailed terms and conditions of E-auction sale, refer TENDER documents available at https://bbi.baanknet.com/eauction-ibbi/home or you may write to liquidator on his email id kkjoseca@gmail.com

Liquidator: CA Kizhakkekara Kuriakose Jose
Reg No - IBSI/PA-001/IP-P00445/2017-2018/10788
E-mail: vysaliprp@gmail.com, kkjoseca@gmail.com
Telephone No: +91 9447913514
For more details: https://bbi.baanknet.com/

Sd/-
CA Kizhakkekara Kuriakose Jose (Liquidator)

Dated: 27-07-2026

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Website: www.sakthifinance.com

NOTICE
(FOR THE ATTENTION OF EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS OF THE COMPANY)
TRANSFER OF EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY TO INVESTOR EDUCATION AND PROTECTION FUND ("IEPF") AUTHORITY

This Notice is published pursuant to the provisions of the Investor Education and Protection Fund ("IEPF") Authority (Accounting, Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules 2016, as amended, notified by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs effective 7th September 2016 (referred to as "the Rules").

The Rules, among other matters, contain provisions for transfer of all shares in respect of which dividend has remained unpaid or unclaimed by the shareholders as per Section 124(6) of the Companies Act 2013, for seven consecutive years from the Financial Year 2018 - 2019 or more in the name of Investor Education and Protection Fund ("IEPF") Authority.

The Company has communicated to the shareholders concerned whose equity shares are liable to be transferred during the financial year 2026-2027 to IEPF Authority under the said Rules.

The Company has uploaded the details of such shareholders whose shares are due for transfer to IEPF Authority on its website at www.sakthifinance.com. Shareholders are requested to verify from the website of the company.

Shareholders may note that both the unclaimed dividend and the equity shares transferred to IEPF Authority including all benefits accruing on such shares, if any, can be reclaimed from IEPF Authority after following the procedure prescribed under the Rules.

The shareholders concerned holding shares in physical form and whose shares are liable to be transferred to IEPF Authority, may note that the Company would be issuing duplicate share certificate(s) in lieu of the original share certificate(s) held by them for the purpose of dematerialization and transfer of shares to IEPF Authority as per Rules and upon such issue, the original share certificate(s) which stand registered in their name will stand automatically cancelled and be deemed non-negotiable. In case of the shareholders concerned holding shares in Demat form, the Company shall transfer the shares by way of corporate action through respective depositories (NSDL/CDSL) to the IEPF authority. The shareholders may further note that the details uploaded by the Company on its website should be regarded and shall be deemed adequate notice in respect of issue of the duplicate share certificate(s) by the Company for the purpose of transfer of shares to IEPF Authority pursuant to the Rules.

In case the Company does not receive any communication from the shareholders concerned on or before 15 October 2026, the Company shall transfer the shares to IEPF Authority as per the procedure stipulated in the Rules.

In case the shareholders have any queries on the subject matter, they may contact the following addresses:

S.Venkatesh Company Secretary and Chief Compliance Officer Sakthi Finance Limited Regd. Office : 62, Dr. Nanjappa Road Coimbatore - 641 018 Ph : (0422) 4236207 E-mail : svenkatesh@sakthifinance.com Website : www.sakthifinance.com	Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent MUGF Intime India Private Limited "Surya", 35, Mayflower Avenue Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road Coimbatore - 641 028 Ph : (0422) 4958995, 2539835 - 836 Fax : (0422) 2539837 E-mail : investors.helpdesk@in.mpmf.com Website : https://in.mpmf.com
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For Sakthi Finance Limited
S. Venkatesh
Company Secretary and Chief Compliance Officer
FCS 7012

25 July 2026
Coimbatore - 18

A doctor’s reflective tale

Dispels many notions on liver health, treatment

BOOK REVIEW.

PT Jyothi Datta

The opening pages of *The Liver Doctor* reveal a thinking that may not quite sit with the online persona of its author Dr Cyriac Abby Philips.

“From the time you are born, Death becomes your friend. The only one destined to advance towards you and finally embrace you. Death is your friend. Always has been,” he says, on the journey of a medical professional, dealing with death at some point. “I became a doctor not to help people cheat Death but to prepare them to understand it and, in the process, learn the value of embracing life,” he writes, rather sensitively.

The online persona of the doctor, though, is a polarising one calling out traditional systems of medicine, in a manner that appears to pander to the gladiatorial audience on social media, rather than engage in a civil scientific argument, more becoming of a respected doctor. Perhaps his book gives readers an idea of why that is.

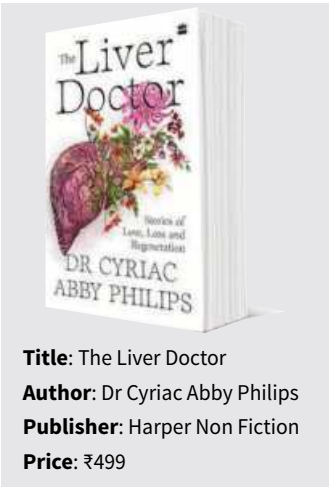
Initially, he did engage on microblogging site Twitter (now X) to explain liver health. He was surprised with its “power to change public perception and spark meaningful dialogue...” But his first encounter, “was not entirely pleasant”, he says.

His stated purpose was to share insights on liver injuries and the risks of alternative medicines. But that brought on the trolls and he was called a host of things, including a “big-pharma endorser” for discussing studies that slammed Ayurvedic therapies, he recalls.

STORIES OF PATIENTS

Overwhelmed by the abuse, he took a pause and came back — only to find that Twitter (X) had not changed, but the way he communicated with the “often harsh crowd” had, he says, as he started sharing stories of patient families — on herbal liver injuries, liver diseases, drug-induced injuries, and effects of alcohol. These were stories of “challenging diagnoses and exhausting battles fought within hospital walls — sometimes ending in the loss of a patient”.

This pattern reflects in his book too, as he takes us through the stories of 14-year-old SaiKrishna, who came in “jaundiced and lethargic”. Hailing from a lower-economic background, and



Title: The Liver Doctor
Author: Dr Cyriac Abby Philips
Publisher: Harper Non Fiction
Price: ₹499

possibly needing an expensive (₹25 lakh) liver transplant — the doctor takes us through her medical journey and his assessment of the damage caused by anti-seizure syrups, prescribed by an ayurvedic practitioner. There is also the incident of Shankar, and his recurrent brain failures — his treatment, getting discharged from hospital after three weeks and throwing the “Kayam Churna (that he was consuming as a laxative) out of the window”.

Unlike the doctor’s approach on Twitter (X), the book is readable, and the patient stories delve into liver conditions and products that trigger health issues. The finger-pointing of ayurvedic products continues, and it comes with explanations.

While the patient stories outline the doctor and his patients’ experiences — with reasoning that’s insightful — a reader with a scientific mind is left searching for more detail to connect the dots.

For example, in the case of modern medicine, a drug is prescribed to treat a specific problem, prescribed for a period of time, followed-up with diagnostic tests to monitor outcomes.

The book does not seem to indicate if the traditional products prescribed to his patients were indicated for a limited time, to be monitored thereafter. That question lingers. Indiscriminate use of any product, traditional or otherwise, could lead to disastrous outcomes. As doctors themselves will tell you, no medicine is without a side-effect.

That said, the book is engaging and reveals aspects of traditional products that are not often explained in as many words. As a doctor’s journey, it reveals moments of vulnerability that doctors often bury and soldier on.

A timely portrait of Karnataka’s CM

The book captures the man of the moment, but could have been clearer on facts and provided an in-depth look at some aspects

BOOK REVIEW.

Venkatesha Babu

In the cacophonous democracy that India is, it is a pity that we do not have more books chronicling political leaders, parties and defining moments in the world’s largest democracy. Political biographies and insider accounts remain surprisingly few and far between.

Rasheed Kidwai, a veteran Congress watcher with impeccable credentials and deep access to the party’s top leadership, is well placed to tell such stories. His latest book, *Congress’s Crisis Manager, Karnataka’s Kingmaker: DK Shivakumar*, arrives at a particularly opportune moment. After nearly three years of intense speculation and internal manoeuvring, the Congress high command finally persuaded Siddaramaiah to step down and elevated Shivakumar as Karnataka’s Chief Minister in June this year.

The book traces Shivakumar’s journey from student politics to the State’s highest office, peppering the narrative with anecdotes and insider accounts. However, for long-time observers of Karnataka politics, much of the material will already be familiar. The Ahmed Patel Rajya Sabha election of 2017 and the episode involving the sequestering of 44 Gujarat Congress MLAs at Bengaluru’s Eagleton Resort receive extensive attention — perhaps more than they warrant, given how often these incidents have already been recounted.

The author argues that Shivakumar has emerged as the tallest Vokkaliga leader after former Prime Minister HD Deve Gowda. That conclusion appears premature. While Deve Gowda, now 93, is in the twilight of his political career, his son HD Kumaraswamy remains an active and influential force. Having already served twice as Chief Minister, Kumaraswamy has an equally strong

claim to leadership within the community.

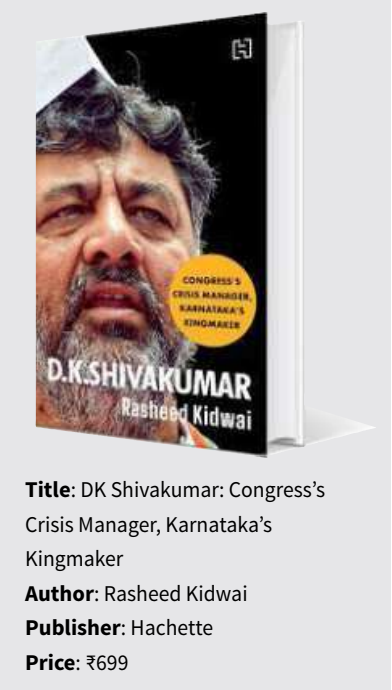
The book is also inconsistent in its demographic estimates. It cites Lingayats as constituting 21 per cent of Karnataka’s population at one point, while elsewhere placing the figure between 11 and 17 per cent. Similarly, Vokkaligas are variously estimated at between 10 and 15 per cent. Some uncertainty is understandable because successive governments have refrained from officially releasing the findings of the State’s caste survey. The reluctance is widely attributed to concerns that the actual demographic weight of the dominant communities may differ significantly from long-held assumptions.

A CONGRESS STRONGHOLD

Kidwai perhaps overstates the centrality of Siddaramaiah and his clever co-option of AHINDA (Kannada acronym for minorities, backward classes and Dalits) coalition in explaining Congress’s success. Historically, Karnataka has been one of the Congress’s strongest States. Even when the BJP has formed governments, the Congress has often secured a higher share of the popular vote. In 2008, for instance, the Congress polled marginally more votes than the BJP, yet the BJP formed its first government in the State. The pattern repeated in 2018, when the Congress again secured a higher vote share but emerged with fewer seats because of the first-past-the-post electoral system.

Equally debatable is the suggestion that the Congress has sought to shift Karnataka’s politics from caste-based mobilisation to issue-based politics. The State’s electoral politics continues to be deeply shaped by identity. If the BJP has attempted to consolidate voters around religious identity, the Congress has focused on caste coalitions while relying heavily on support from minority communities.

One charming anecdote recounts



Title: DK Shivakumar: Congress's Crisis Manager, Karnataka's Kingmaker
Author: Rasheed Kidwai
Publisher: Hachette
Price: ₹699

Shivakumar’s sister, Manjula, showing her hand to a fortune-teller and recounting this to her brother who retorted, “Why show your palm to know your future? You should shape your own future.” It is an admirable sentiment, although it sits uneasily with Shivakumar’s own well-known belief in astrology and fortune-telling.

The book also creates an impression that Shivakumar emerged from an impoverished rural background. That portrayal is only partly accurate. Shivakumar himself has acknowledged on several occasions that his family was relatively well-off. His education at institutions such as National Public School and Vidyavardhaka Sangha — among Bengaluru’s better-known schools at the time — suggests a family with considerable means.

Similarly, the book portrays Shivakumar as an unwavering loyalist of

the Gandhi family throughout his political career. The reality is somewhat more nuanced. In 1994, after being denied a Congress ticket, he contested as an Independent and won, before eventually returning to the party fold.

One notable omission is the controversy surrounding the proposed 114-foot statue of Jesus Christ at Kapalabetta in Kanakapura. On Christmas Day in 2019, Shivakumar participated in the foundation-laying ceremony and contributed over ₹10 lakh to the project. The BJP alleged that the site was a hill sacred to Lord Shiva and that government land had been illegally earmarked for the monument. The project became embroiled in legal disputes and eventually faded from public attention.

There are also factual inaccuracies.

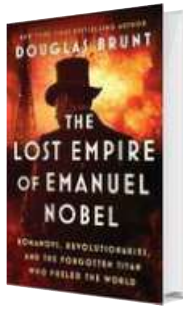
On page 51, Veerappa Moily is described as a Vokkaliga leader, whereas he belongs to the Devadiga community.

While the book briefly touches upon Shivakumar’s business interests — particularly in education and real estate — it stops well short of examining the remarkable expansion of his wealth. His declared assets increased from ₹251.51 crore in his 2013 Assembly election affidavit to ₹1,413.8 crore in 2023, making him one of India’s wealthiest elected politicians. A dedicated chapter examining this aspect of his public life would have substantially strengthened the book.

Where Kidwai is at his best is in narrating developments within the Congress at the national level. His account of the Indira Gandhi era and the political manoeuvring within the party’s central leadership is engaging, authoritative and highly readable.

Ultimately though, the book is a timely and worthwhile read. It provides useful insights into Shivakumar’s political evolution but falls short of offering the definitive biography that such an important political figure deserves.

NEW READS.

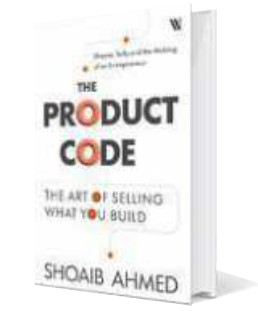


Title: The Lost Empire of Emanuel Nobel

Author: Douglas Brunt

Publisher: Atria Books

The book chronicles one of the most influential men in history — a man whose name has been stricken from memory is thrillingly returned to life

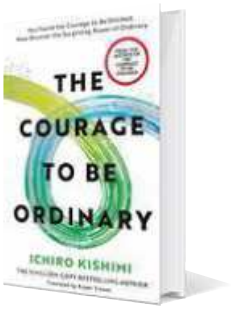


Title: The Product Code

Author: Shoaib Ahmed

Publisher: Westland Business

The author shares a two-pronged formula for success: building software that solves real-world human problems and nurturing human relationships



Title: The Courage to be Ordinary

Author: Ichiro Kishimi

Publisher: Vermilion

Being ordinary isn’t failure — it’s freedom. Freedom from constant competition, from chasing approval, from feeling habitually tense

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

July 27, 2006

Govt does not endorse RIL gas price formula

The Government did not agree with the Mukesh Ambani led Reliance Industries’ proposed valuation formula for gas sales to Reliance Natural Resources Ltd belonging to Anil Ambani Group. The Petroleum Ministry said it has not been derived on the basis of competitive arm’s length sale pricing.

CBI awaits Govt nod to book officials in corruption cases

The Central Bureau of Investigation has stepped up its anti-corruption drive in the past three-and-a-half years with the number of corruption cases registered by it going up significantly each year since 2003.. According to the rules, the CBI needs the sanction from the Ministry concerned to initiate proceedings in case of officials in the rank of Joint Secretary and above.

Street vendors demand to be organised

The roadside hawker is no insignificant entity. In a rough estimate, they contribute ₹86,000-crore annually to the country’s GDP. Demanding the creation of a Task Force to implement the street vendor national policy, over 270 hawkers from all over the country congregated at the All India Street Vendors Jansunwayi (public hearing).

Vikrampati Singhania

On July 15, 2026, as the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) came into effect, the Government of India flagged off one of the first export consignments under the Agreement. The consignment was from Brakes India, an Indian automotive components manufacturer.

It underscored the growing stature of India’s automotive components industry and the confidence that Indian companies have earned in global markets through decades of investment in quality, technology and engineering excellence.

In many ways, that first shipment marked the beginning of a new chapter,

one in which India is increasingly recognised not merely as a competitive manufacturing destination, but as a trusted partner in shaping the future of global mobility.

The India-UK CETA provides the foundation for a deeper manufacturing partnership that combines India’s scale and manufacturing competitiveness with the UK’s strengths in advanced engineering, innovation and technology. The timing is significant. As the global automotive industry navigates geopolitical uncertainty, supply chain realignments and rapid tech change, trusted partnerships have become as important as competitive costs.

India’s automotive components industry enters this new phase from a position of strength. Today, it is a \$86 billion industry with exports of \$24

billion, reflecting decades of investment in engineering capability, quality systems and manufacturing excellence.

The UK is already an important partner. Automotive components export to the UK grew by nearly 11 per cent during FY26 to \$801 million, highlighting the complementarity between the two industries. India has emerged as a globally competitive supplier across a broad spectrum of automotive products, while the UK remains a leader in advanced engineering, research, testing, design and next-generation mobility technologies. Together, these strengths create opportunities far beyond bilateral trade. As the industry transitions towards electric, connected and software-defined vehicles, the partnership can accelerate innovation,

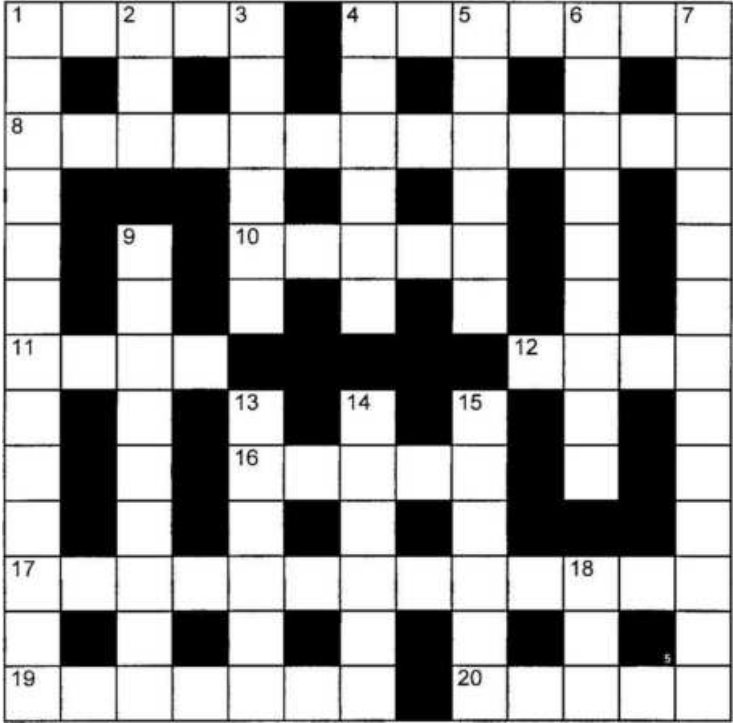
attract investment and strengthen resilient global supply chains.

For India’s MSMEs, the agreement offers an opportunity to deepen technology partnerships, upgrade capabilities and integrate more closely with global value chains. Ultimately, the success of the India-UK CETA will be measured not by tariff reductions alone, but by the supplier relationships, technologies, investments and globally competitive products it helps create.

The first consignment under the Agreement may have carried automotive components, but it also carried the confidence, capability and global aspirations of India’s automotive components industry.

The writer is President ACMA and Vice Chairman and MD, JK Fenner (India) Ltd

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2701



EASY

ACROSS

- (Bear the) shock, force of blow (5)
- Lateen-sailed Mediterranean ship (7)
- Spoiling oneself too much (13)
- Find solution (5)
- Requirement (4)
- At an altitude (4)
- Hooded shirt, coat (5)
- Giving to the public welfare (13)
- Goes on vexing, embittering (7)
- List of jurors (5)

DOWN

- Material for soaking up excess ink (8,5)
- Employment (3)
- A desire for drink (6)
- Violin (6)
- Composed, soothed (6)
- Disposition to believe (9)
- Of the science of heavenly bodies (13)
- Exactness, minute accuracy (9)
- Spread stragglingly (6)
- For nothing, free (6)
- A powerful, ostentatious, rich governor (6)
- Peg, nail (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Being so burnt is a shock to be borne (5)
- Cue calf that could be under sail in the Mediterranean (7)
- Pampering one too much with gold : unit never changes (13)
- Find an answer to love’s entanglement (5)
- Have to have been born a woman, a daughter (4)
- Is well up the scale – of being drunk? (4)
- Hyde had a windproof garment such as this (5)
- Benevolent chap in RH plot one sorted out (13)
- It goes on irritating the right joints (7)
- Board with switches in a different plane (5)

DOWN

- GP, able to print something as absorbing as this (8,5)
- Custom one may turn to one’s advantage (3)
- T-shirt designed to show it being satisfied with a drink (6)
- It is something to bow and scrape, but it’s a swindle (6)
- Soothed by three quid due to be handed out (6)
- Willingness to believe it ruled out in the City (9)
- It’s about star study (ps : Charity also comes into it) (13)
- Accuracy in price is no substitute for it (9)
- Lie untidily, with paws flung left and right (6)
- Deserter is being held by American soldiers for nothing (6)
- Leave one another as he turns up, the tyrant (6)
- One’s debit card number may have its point (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2700

ACROSS 1. Stood 4. Through 8. Overslept 9. Par 10. Lookout 12. Tree 14. Demoted 17. Bias 18. Paddock 20. All 21. Embroider 23. Entreat 24. Model

DOWN 1. Shoulder blade 2. Oberon 3. Discover 4. Tee 5. Ruth 6. Umpire 7. Horse mackerel 11. Troop 13. Headroom 15. Wallet 16. Sordid 19. Cede 22. Bat

ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

Humour, nostalgia and a return to simplicity powered some of the campaigns we saw in the past fortnight

A life with colour

Berger Paints' new campaign unveiled a refreshed brand identity anchored in a simple belief: Whatever life may test us with, it should never take away our colour. The campaign 'Rang Bana Rahe' is as much a perspective on life as it is on paints, celebrating the way in which people hold on to their colours of individuality and spirit. At the centre of the campaign is a circus artist — a clown named Khushrangi, whose colours never fade, come rain or shine. Through the depiction of a day in his life, the film created by Sideways Consulting shows how people and even homes can hold on to their colours.

Praise without words

Greenlam Laminates' new film, 'Taareefein Dikhai Dengi', created by Dentsu Creative Webchutney, draws on the insight that while people are quick to voice opinions, they are often reserved with compliments. Using the old film song 'Na Bole Tum, Na Maine Kuch Kaha' as a metaphor for appreciation that needs no words, the film shows a couple welcoming friends to their renovated home. The guests are left speechless by the interiors crafted with Greenlam Laminates and, for the couple, the stares are appreciation enough. Significantly, the ad is in a longer format at 45 seconds and 60 seconds, instead of 30 seconds, stemming from the brand's belief that good stories cannot be rushed.

Back to basics

Jyothy Labs' new campaign for its bioenzyme-powered anti-bacterial EXO range of dishwashing solutions, created by a simple agency, a unit of Loggerheads, uses a dual-voice strategy to build stronger connections with audiences across the country. Yami Gautam leads the communication across North, East and West India, while Keerthy Suresh becomes the voice of the brand in the southern states. The campaign keeps the product firmly at the heart of the story, and drills home — very simply — how well the dishwashing liquid does its job.

The death trap

Most road safety campaigns tell drivers what they are doing wrong. SaveLIFE Foundation's latest behaviour change campaign, 'Nuksaan Ka Sauda', focuses on the 'why'. The seven-film digital series, with creative development by McCann Worldgroup, shows that many road crashes happen not because of recklessness or indifference but pure economics. In an attempt to save every penny, the average Indian compromises — from using cheap helmets to overloading vehicles — not realising it can be fatal. Three of the films feature hyperlocal content creators drawn from the truck driving, cab driving and motorcyclist communities.

NUGGETS.

From chips to cafes

In March this year, snack brand Lays, from the Pepsico stable, launched Pilla Tortilla in Madrid, an eatery serving traditional Spanish tortillas using the brand's crisps as a core ingredient. In April this year, it opened Lay's Potato Restaurant in Shanghai, in the Xintiandi lifestyle district, offering potato-inspired dishes, fashion collaborations and exclusive merchandise. According to VML Intelligence, snack brands searching for growth outside retail shelves are increasingly vying for a share of the consumer's weekend by investing in restaurants. Haldiram's, in India, is a veteran in that concept and has recently expanded into London with a 120-seat eatery.

Tuning in free

Despite music being among the most consumed forms of digital entertainment in India, paid music streaming remains significantly underpenetrated, according to a report by EY and the Indian Music Industry (IMI), titled 'How India listens, streams and pays for music'. It estimates India had about 14 million paid music subscriptions in 2025 and this could touch 28–30 million by 2028, supported by product innovation, partnerships and evolving consumer preferences. The report, surveying about 15,000 smartphone users across India, found a substantial gap between consumption and monetisation. While 86 per cent pay for video OTT services at some point, only 38 per cent pay for a music streaming service.

● BIG SCREEN REBOUND

Popcorn, premium seats and mega hits

FULL HOUSE. H1 2026 marks the highest post-pandemic cinema revenue, driven by advance sales and surging demand for luxury formats



ACTION! (From left) Top grosser Dhurandhar: The Revenge; The Odyssey earned ₹100 crore within a week; and a newly opened theatre in Tiruchi, as the movie market booms in tier-2 centres and beyond

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

From luxury seating to packed single screens, India's box office is witnessing a historic, post-pandemic surge this year. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, which crossed ₹100 crore in gross collections within the first week of its release, is just the latest blockbuster riding the wave. What's remarkable is the broad-based growth across Hindi, Hollywood and regional language films, making it the highest grossing first half of any year post Covid. With a strong line-up of films in the second half, the year promises to be a milestone one for movie ticket sales, which are expected to cross the ₹15,000 crore mark, according to Ormax Media. PVR INOX's investor presentation states that box-office collections in India grew 20 per cent in the January-June period to ₹6,665 crore from ₹5,570 crore a year ago, outpacing international markets. What enthuses Sanjeev Kumar Bijli, Executive Director, PVR INOX, is the growth beyond metros

in tier-2 and tier-3 markets. "Consumers are coming to watch not just the big-budget films but also the mid-scale and small films that are not star-driven," he said. **BOX-OFFICE BOOM** Notes Bijli, "Films that are now touching the ₹100 crore mark were, even two years ago, stopping at ₹30-40 crore. *Main Vaapas Aaunga* has grossed nearly ₹100 crore. A horror English film like *Obsession* also garnered ₹100 crore. These are all sleeper hits, and such smaller movies earning nearly ₹100 crore is a very positive sign." He points to how star-driven films like *Bhoot Bangla* are garnering over ₹200 crore. At the same time, regional cinema is witnessing multi-fold growth. Earlier this month, the Multiplex Association of India, too, had pointed out that a healthy mix of blockbuster franchises, original stories, regional cinema and international releases had resonated with audiences across India in the first half of the year. According to Ormax Media, *Dhurandhar: The Revenge* and *Bor-der 2* in Hindi and *Peddi* in Telugu

were the top three grossers in the January-June period. Six films crossed the ₹200 crore mark, compared to four a year ago, the media consulting firm said. *Project Hail Mary* and *Obsession* were among the top 15 grossers, indicating the strong run enjoyed by Hollywood productions in India; the hype surrounding *The Odyssey* and *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* is further proof of this. **AUDIENCE ADVOCACY** Devang Sampat, MD, Cinepolis India, said, "After a strong performance in H1 and, given the robust content pipeline for the second half of the year, we expect to see this year's box-office collection outperforming historical benchmarks. The internal metric we closely monitor is the number of consumers visiting the cinema... The million-plus-footfall movies have been growing year-on-year." Echoing this, Ashish Saksena, COO-Cinemas, BookMyShow, said India's movie theatre success is no longer driven by one language or genre. "We've seen greater stability in box-office trends compared to the immediate post-pandemic

years. Rather than relying on one or two tent-pole releases, we're seeing a wider mix of films sustaining theatrical momentum through audience advocacy and positive word-of-mouth," he said. "*Main Vaapas Aaunga*, for instance, continued to perform steadily in cinemas weeks after release, despite audiences knowing it would eventually arrive on OTT." Movies like *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*, *Jana Nayagan* in Tamil and *The Odyssey* have seen stellar advance bookings. "Consumers are increasingly booking tickets earlier, driven by anticipation around upcoming releases, rather than waiting for reviews or word of mouth, which reflects a growing confidence in today's theatrical slate. Another encouraging indicator is the gradual pickup in weekend business across a wider range of films," Sak-sena said. **PREMIUMISATION** Leading multiplex chains are adding screens. "There is a lot of headroom for growth. We are looking at adding 40 screens per year across the key catchments, irrespective of whether it is tier-1,

tier-2 or metro," said Sampat. Movie-goers are increasingly value conscious rather than price conscious, driving a premiumisation trend. "*The Odyssey* is a great example of this shift. Many audiences chose to wait to experience the film in IMAX rather than watching in a standard format," said Sak-sena, adding this is driving investments in upgrading the exhibition ecosystem, including sound, projection and overall in-cinema experiences. Moreover, globally, filmmakers are increasingly designing films that are best experienced in the premium formats. "Almost 20 per cent of our circuit is premium screens like IMAX, 4DX, ICE, ScreenX, Insignia and Director's Cut. These formats offer a more immersive experience, and we are committed to expanding them as consumers are willing to pay more for the differentiation," Bijli said. The big-ticket line-up for the second half of the year, including *Ramayana: Part 1, King, Toxic, Fauzi, Jailer 2, Avengers: Domsday* and *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*, promises to keep the cash registers ringing for longer.

● DESIGNING DESIRE

When brands make you sleuth around to discover them

Vatsala Bisen

When we stand in a super-market or scroll through e-commerce, the hand always moves faster than the mind and the best kind of brands understand this. They don't want you to know, they want you to wonder. Take, for example, the mobile phone landscape of 2022. Every major tech giant was engaged in a desperate race for technical specs. The air was thick with megapixels, battery capacities and imaging chips. So, what could a new entrant even say at this time to be heard? Carl Pei decided it was "Nothing". He simply posted a few visual clues on X and let the internet do its thing. The phone debuted at an exhibition in Basel, like some piece of art. And sold over half a million units in the first five months. **AWAKENING CURIOSITY** This is the deliberate mastery of strategic desire. The most magnetic brands in the world understand that explaining your product is often the fastest way to kill the magic.

What you really need to do is create something that hits the lizard brain first, compelling us to lean in and ask: "I like it. What is it?" Take the retro-futuristic toy-like design of the Swedish tech brand Teenage Engineering, which makes cult-classic audio products, aesthetic synthesisers and dynamic performance sequencers. The shiny chrome-and-orange body, with mysterious dials and no instructions, makes us want to hold it, flip it and rush to show it to our friends. We may not know how to sequence a beat but we sure want to collect them all. It can also be used to flip the script — building desire for products for which we have developed a blind spot. For generations, canned fish was a pantry staple hidden on the lowest super-market shelves. Founded and led by a woman, the company Fishwife, which sells ethically sourced tinned seafood, took this dusty category and wrapped it in vibrant, hand-illustrated boxes that look like pop art. Lo and behold! Instagram found a new darling. Fishwife's colourful boxes now appear on kitchen counters for the love of aesthetic



SOLD ON AESTHETICS. Fishwife seafood, and a Total Environment home



joy. The tinned fish just happens to be inside it. Or how Graza, based in Brooklyn, US, playfully disrupted the olive oil category with a vibrant, squeezable green bottle, leading to a whole host of me-toos. And sometimes desire comes from stubborn opacity. Luxury cosmetics brand Aesop's stores carry a refusal to explain. Customers are made to feel like they are being invited into someone's home and, before you know it, you are washing

your hands at their central stone basin and rearranging your whole home to match the two bottles on your bathroom shelf. **CATERING TO TASTE** Closer home, take Total Environment. For decades, Indian real estate sold through brute-force aspiration, focusing on marble lobbies, infinity pools and names like 'Grandeur' or 'Elysium'. Total Environment bypassed the mega-

phone, not bothering with introductions. It built homes where banyan trees burst through living rooms and rainwater cascaded down interior walls. But the real mastery of desire was in the naming. Instead of selling status, they catered to taste. The building names were centred around music and other aesthetics — 'In That Quiet Earth', 'Windmills of Your Mind' and 'Down by the Water'. It created an instant insider view. If you got the reference, you were one of them. It shifted the needle from 'showing' to 'knowing'. Awareness is what you rent. Desire is what you own. Most brands are paying extraordinary rates for rented attention, but true innovators prefer to make you sleuth. By stepping back and leaving room for curiosity, they transform their product from an item to be sold to a treasure to be discovered. Because, ultimately, the most powerful question a brand can generate should not be "What do you do?", but the far more compelling "Where did you get that?"

Vatsala Bisen is Executive Creative Director, OPEN Strategy & Design

Every weekend is now a time of festive spending and cheer

How urban India's booming weekend economy is a huge opportunity for marketers and city planners

THE CURIOUS MARKETER
HARISH BHAT

On a recent Saturday evening, I was at Church Street in central Bengaluru. It was virtually impossible to walk on this road because it was jam-packed with hundreds of shoppers and revellers. There were long queues to get into restaurants. The nearby metro station was teeming with people. It looked like a festival day, though it was just another weekend. Then, on Sunday afternoon, I attended a talk on quantum physics, given by a friend. It was held at a pub in Koramangala, with entry priced above ₹1,000 per person, inclusive of snacks. I was surprised to see a full house — more than 120 people — all totally engaged, with intellect and food. The talk was fabulous. Once again, just another weekend in Bangalore. A day later, the penny dropped when I read an excellent report, 'The many urban Indias', pub-

lished by PRICE and Tata Sons, and authored by Rajesh Shukla, Roopa Purushothaman and Vishal Vaibhaw. A key observation was the emergence of the 'weekend economy' in urban India. The report highlighted how, on average, urban consumers spend ₹6,724 during weekdays and ₹10,732 each weekend. This implies that 61.5 per cent of weekly spending is concentrated on just Saturday and Sunday. Spending on discretionary products — fashion and apparel, entertainment and electronics — virtually doubles during weekends. Spending on essential items — groceries and healthcare — also moves higher during weekends, though moderately. This weekend splurge is seen across the top 100 cities, not just metros. Why are weekends so big? What has driven this big shift to the urban weekend economy? My hypothesis is there are three key reasons for it. ■ First, with dual-income households far more common in Indian cities, families have little or no time to spend money meaningfully on weekdays because of long hours at work and travel. Simil-



LISTEN UP. A live music show keeps weekend crowds engaged at a pedestrian-first space in Chennai VELANKANNI RAJ B

arly, children are tied up with school, tuitions and other activities. This leaves only weekends for shopping, family outings or other leisure experiences. ■ Second, there is a distinct mindset change when people enter weekends — we want to let our hair down and spend on experiences that recharge our physical and emotional batteries. This contrasts with the hectic weekday, where productivity is the key goal. In short, the weekday urbanite is

psychographically different from the weekend urbanite. ■ Third, in today's digital-fuelled world, people are constantly seeking hits of adrenaline. On weekends, they get these hits from work, and interactions with colleagues. Come weekend, they need to escape to nearby resorts or eat fancy meals or indulge in shopping therapy to obtain their shots of pleasure. So, what can marketers and cities do to ride this weekend wave?

Here are some thoughts. Retail stores can stay open longer on weekends, and cities can facilitate this. Recently, I saw a store turn away a customer who came in around 9 pm on Sunday evening. Retail stores can also design special experiences for customers over the weekends — such as nail art or *mehendi* or Mediterranean cooking classes — which can prove very engaging. Brands can also create customised weekend engagement programmes. Cities can demarcate weekend zones, with permission for activities such as busking, food vending, street theatre, book readings and art displays. Public transport, sanitation, road lighting and safety can be stepped up to ensure people have access to reliable, cost-effective travel and feel safe on roads, particularly during late hours. With imagination, city planners and marketers can transform each of the 52 weekends during the year into win-win festivals that engage people beautifully and also generate significant incremental economic activity.

Harish Bhat is an avid marketer and bestselling author

FROM THE LABS.

Additive steps up lubrication

Scientists have shown, for the first time, that borophene — an ultra-thin, two-dimensional nanomaterial — can be used as an effective additive to improve the performance of castor oil as a lubricant. The discovery could help develop greener lubricants for industries such as renewable energy, marine

transport and sustainable manufacturing. Researchers at the Institute of Advanced Study in Science and Technology (IASST), Guwahati, found that adding a tiny amount of borophene — 0.1 per cent by weight — to castor oil can significantly improve its performance. The modified oil reduced friction by about 42 per cent, compared with ordinary castor oil.

The research was carried out under the guidance of Prof Devasish Chowdhury, with INSPIRE senior research fellow Ujjibit Boruah as the first author. The findings could lead to the development of environment friendly lubricants that make machines run more efficiently, reduce damage and lower energy consumption.

“Two-dimensional materials have attracted huge interest because of their unique properties. Borophene, in particular, has shown promise in areas such as batteries, supercapacitors and fuel cells. However, its use as a lubricant additive had not been explored until now,” said Prof Chowdhury.

The researchers found that borophene mixes evenly with castor oil without needing any chemical treatment. When the lubricant is used inside machines, the borophene particles help form a thin protective layer, called tribofilm, on metal surfaces. This layer contains iron oxides, carbon-based compounds and boron compounds. It reduces friction between moving surfaces, allows machines to handle higher loads and protects against wear.

Next-gen battery electrode

Researchers in India have developed a new organic electrode material that could help accelerate the development of sodium-ion batteries, a promising alternative to lithium-ion batteries for largescale energy storage.

As demand for batteries grows for electric vehicles, renewable energy storage and electronic devices, researchers worldwide are looking for alternatives to lithium, which faces challenges related to cost, supply chains and resource availability. Sodium, in contrast, is widely available, making sodium-ion batteries an attractive option.

A joint team from the Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science (IACS) and SN Bose National Centre for Basic Sciences (SNBNCBS), Kolkata, has developed a new covalent organic framework (COF) material that can store sodium ions efficiently.

The team, led by Dr Urmimala Maitra of IACS and Dr Pradip Pachfule of SNBNCBS, designed the porous organic material to allow charged ions to move easily while maintaining structural stability during repeated charging and discharging.

When tested in battery cells, the material demonstrated good energy storage performance and its ability to work as an electrode for sodium-ion batteries. The material also performs well in lithium-ion batteries, enabling rapid charging, with the laboratory cell reaching 80 per cent charge in just over one minute.

The material's porous structure provides pathways through which ions can travel quickly, while its stable chemical framework helps prevent degradation during cycling. This combination of rapid ion transport and durability is a key challenge in designing next-generation battery electrodes.

The study highlights how molecular-level design of organic materials can help overcome some of the limitations of sodium-ion batteries, which currently lag lithium-ion batteries in energy density and commercial maturity.

● REPURPOSING FURNACES

Tata Steel’s coke-cutting EASyMelt tech

CLEAN TRANSITION. Company explores pathway to reducing coke usage while retaining existing steel-making infrastructure

M Ramesh

In April this year, Tata Steel put out a brief announcement stating it had “entered into definitive agreements with Paul Wurth, SA (Luxembourg), part of SMS Group GmbH, for implementation of the world’s first EASyMelt (electrically-assisted syngas smelter) technology”.

Behind the jargon lies an ambitious attempt to tackle one of the hardest problems in industrial decarbonisation: How to reduce emissions from existing blast furnaces without replacing the furnaces altogether?

The blast furnace remains the dominant means of producing iron globally. EASyMelt modifies the furnace to help use the gases emitted during the various segments of steel making to convert iron ore to iron. This significantly reduces dependence on coke, the indispensable ingredient in steel making that is also responsible for much of the carbon dioxide emissions from steel plants.

However, the process of producing coke from coal — heating metallurgical coal in coke ovens — is also rich in hydrogen and methane.

Tata Steel believes EASyMelt could offer a pathway to reducing coke consumption while retaining much of the existing steel-making infrastructure.

Subodh Pandey, VP Technology, R&D, NMB and Graphene, told *businessline* that EASyMelt represents a combination of three process improvement technologies that have been demonstrated individually elsewhere but never integrated in this manner before.

● The first step is dry reforming, which creates the reducing gas needed by the blast furnace.

An integrated steel plant produces several gases. One of them is coke oven gas, generated during the



CARBON-INTENSIVE. In a blast furnace, the heat balance is maintained through reactions involving coke

production of coke from coal. Rather than being simply burnt as fuel, coke oven gas can be used as a chemical feedstock because it contains large quantities of hydrogen and methane. “Coke oven gas is gold,” said Pandey.

The methane in coke oven gas is reacted with carbon dioxide from blast furnace gas in a dry reformer. The reaction converts these gases into synthesis gas (syngas), a mixture primarily containing carbon monoxide and hydrogen — the very gases that help reduce iron ore (by driving out the oxygen in the ore).

In effect, a gas that would otherwise contain a significant amount of carbon dioxide is converted into a fresh stream of reducing gases.

● The second process is shaft injection. In a conventional blast furnace, most reducing gases enter from the bottom and travel upwards. Shaft injection introduces the newly produced reducing gas higher up in the furnace.

This allows the iron ore burden to begin losing oxygen earlier in its journey through the furnace, reducing the chemical work needed in

the hottest region below.

● The third process is tuyere injection. Tuyeres are water-cooled nozzles located near the bottom of the blast furnace, through which hot gases are normally blown into the furnace. This is the zone where coke combustion generates high temperatures and the carbon monoxide required for iron making.

By injecting reducing gases through the tuyeres, EASyMelt supplies carbon monoxide and hydrogen directly to the region where reduction is most intensive. This reduces the need for coke to generate those gases inside the furnace.

THERMAL SHIFT

“The idea is that, instead of making all the reducing gases inside the furnace using coke, we make them outside and inject them back in,” Pandey explained. The “electrically assisted” component of EASyMelt refers to the use of electrically generated heat to raise the temperature of the reducing gases before they are injected into the blast furnace. In a conventional furnace, the heat balance is maintained largely



Subodh Pandey, VP Technology, R&D, NMB and Graphene, Tata Steel

through carbon-based reactions involving coke. By shifting a part of the thermal requirement to electricity, EASyMelt seeks to cut the reliance on carbon for both chemical reduction and heat generation.

The company’s board has approved an investment of ₹2,500 crore to modify a blast furnace at its Jamshedpur facility for the deployment of the EASyMelt technology.

Pandey, however, cautioned that the coke reduction figure is an expectation, which will be tested through the project. “Our bet is

that coke consumption should fall from 440 kg per tonne of hot metal to 220 kg,” he said. That would imply nearly 50 per cent reduction in coke consumption, if achieved.

EASyMelt was developed by SMS Group, the global equipment supplier, which approached Tata Steel with the technology.

“We had the appetite to try out this new approach,” Pandey said.

The Jamshedpur project could also be the beginning of a wider roll-out within Tata Steel’s operations. Pandey said he believed that around 20 per cent of the company’s blast furnaces — corresponding to 4-5 million tonnes of hot metal — could potentially be modified to adopt the EASyMelt approach. The attractiveness of the technology lies precisely in this possibility — reducing emissions from existing assets, rather than waiting for replacement with newer technologies.

EASyMelt is Tata Steel’s second low-carbon pathway to steel production. The company earlier worked on Hisarna (read ‘The molten magic inside Tata Steel’s Hisarna bet’ in *businessline* dated April 20, 2026), an alternative iron-making route it developed in collaboration with European partners.

Unlike EASyMelt, which modifies an existing blast furnace, Hisarna seeks to replace the conventional blast furnace-coke oven route altogether. It combines ore preparation and iron reduction in a cyclone converter furnace, eliminating the need for coke ovens and sinter plants and producing a concentrated carbon dioxide stream, which could potentially be captured and stored.

The writer visited the Tata Steel factory in Jamshedpur at the invitation of the company

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to quantum@thehindu.co.in

● WOW. Wake up and smell the cosmos



Team Quantum

Rip Van Winkle slept for 20 years and woke up to find a changed world in the Washington Irving story. NASA’s New Horizons spacecraft ‘slept’ for only 321 days, but its awakening was equally dramatic and scientifically significant.

On June 23, mission controllers of New Horizons, now 9.5 billion km from Earth, ‘woke up’ the spacecraft from the hibernation mode they had placed it in to conserve energy as it cruised along the edges of the solar system. They cheered on discovering all was well with the spacecraft.

Even while ‘asleep’, New Horizons was not idle. Its scientific senses were awake; its instruments continued collecting data on the outer region of the solar system, including solar wind, energetic

particles and tiny dust particles.

Now awake, New Horizons will send stored data back to Earth and begin new observations of the distant heliosphere — the vast bubble around the solar system created by the Sun’s influence. Far ahead of the heliosphere lies the heliopause, the invisible boundary where the Sun’s influence fades away and interstellar space begins. New Horizons is meant to probe the heliopause.

Launched in 2006, it made history as the first spacecraft to fly past Pluto in 2015, and later explored Arrokoth, a distant object in the Kuiper belt. It continues its lonely journey through the outer reaches of the solar system, where few human-made machines have ever ventured.

Only the twin Voyager probes, launched in 1977, have gone farther than New Horizons while still being functional.

● BEYOND LI-ION

Reworking sulphur to win the energy storage race

K Bharat Kumar

Lithium-sulphur (Li-S) batteries have the potential to rule the roost in the next generation of energy storage technology. They come with five times higher energy density than standard lithium-ion batteries, higher capacity (1,675 mAh) and lower raw material cost.

But widespread adoption faces two stumbling blocks — leakage and sluggish reaction.

As the battery functions, the sulphur turns into temporary chemical forms that dissolve into the battery’s liquid. Once dissolved, these molecules freely float back and forth between the positive and negative ends of the battery.

Each time these molecules float away, the battery loses the key materials it needs to store power. This causes the battery to drain rapidly and permanently lose its ability to hold a charge.

Second, charging and discharging the battery requires sulphur to constantly change its chemical state. Sulphur in the mix causes a solid build-up at the end of the discharge phase and this assumes insulating properties. Because electricity cannot pass

through this layer easily, chemical reactions stall. Very slow charge is a common consequence of this build-up.

To prevent the build-up of solids containing sulphur, scientists have toyed with catalysts. Earlier, single metal atoms embedded in graphene (carbon) sheets were used to trap the leaking sulphur.

In a study published earlier this year in the *Small Journal*, researchers Sahil Kumar, et al found a more effective catalyst that used dual atoms.

Dual-atom catalysts (DACs), containing two different metal atoms side-by-side, act like a chemical magnet for the leaking sulphur. They also help split the tough sulphur bonds, allowing the battery to charge and discharge much faster.

ROLE OF AI

Now there are scores of metals and an even greater number of pairings possible.

How do you choose a pair? Trial-and-error method would take ages. The researchers instead used artificial intelligence to build a screening tool they named Precise and Accelerated Configuration Evaluation (PACE). This machine-learning workflow virtually tested 46,400 different struc-

tural arrangements in a short time. It filtered out the poorer options and helped select the optimal metal pairings.

The AI and the follow-up tests showed that the strength of the metal pair mattered a lot in the most suited one.

There are three types of pairs that deal with sulphur — metals like iron paired with titanium grip the sulphur so hard that they warp the catalyst and halt the reaction; some pairs were barely able to hold the sulphur at all.

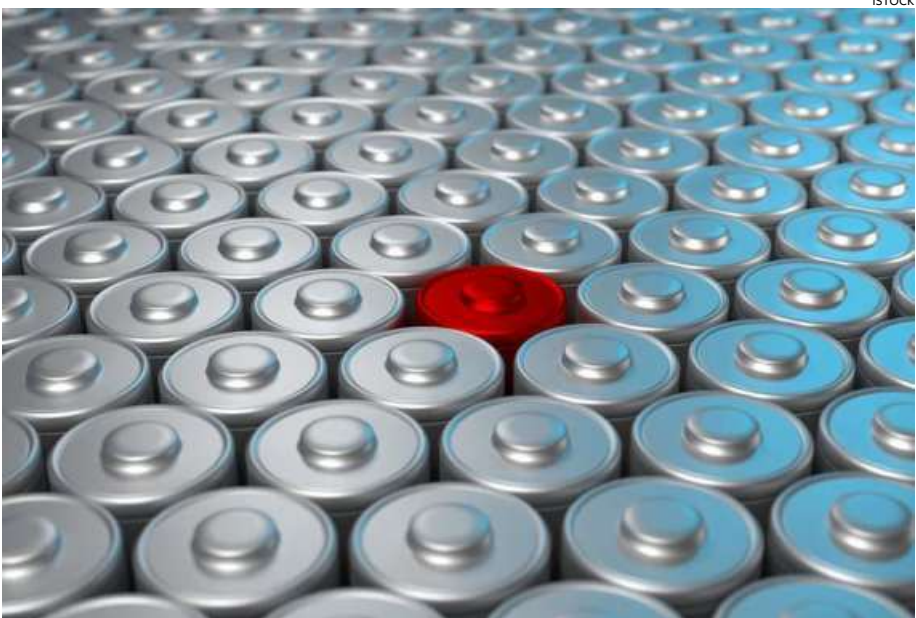
BEST PAIRING

The combination of iron and nickel proved the most optimal.

And why was that?

This pair holds the sulphur tightly enough to halt the leaks but loose enough to allow the completion of the chemical reaction. This pair also used less than half the energy traditionally needed to break down battery waste during charging, and hence sped up the process.

The researchers used their data to train a predictive machine learning model. Now, if new researchers were to try a brand new metal pairing, they can type it into the model, and the computer will instantly predict how well it will perform without the need for new experiments.



ISTOCK

● ELEMENTARY SOLUTION

Tackling iron deficiency from a steel mill

How Tata Steel developed a nutritional supplement from a byproduct of galvanisation

M Ramesh

Anybody who has popped a pill for tackling iron deficiency may have thought, “Why not eat iron itself?” Research at Tata Steel’s Iron Powder Development Centre has indeed made that possible.

Scientists at the centre are trying to give a surprising second life to a humble byproduct of steel making — iron powder.

The story begins with the galvanising process. When steel sheets are coated with zinc to protect them from corrosion, they undergo an acid-washing process. This generates iron-containing material, which when separated from the acid has typically found use in making red oxide pigment for paints.

Tata Steel is now trying to push this iron powder into more advanced applications. One of the most fascinating is a nutritional product: PIRONutri38, an elemental iron powder

developed using Tata Steel’s patented technology.

The idea sounds almost bizarre. Iron is something we associate with bridges, machinery and skyscrapers. The thought that the same element can be part of a nutritional supplement seems counter-intuitive.

But the human body requires iron to make haemoglobin, the protein in red blood cells that carries oxygen. Iron deficiency is one of the most common nutritional disorders globally, but it couldn’t be addressed by swallowing a spoonful of iron powder. To be useful as a nutritional component, the iron must be available in a form that the body can access and absorb.

According to Tata Steel, PIRONutri38 has been developed as a high-bioavailability elemental iron powder. The bioavailability indicates how much iron becomes available for the human body under the conditions of the stomach.

The chemistry behind this is crucial. For iron to be useful nutrition-



ISTOCK

ally, it must first dissolve in the acidic environment of the stomach, so that it can become available for absorption.

TASTE TEST

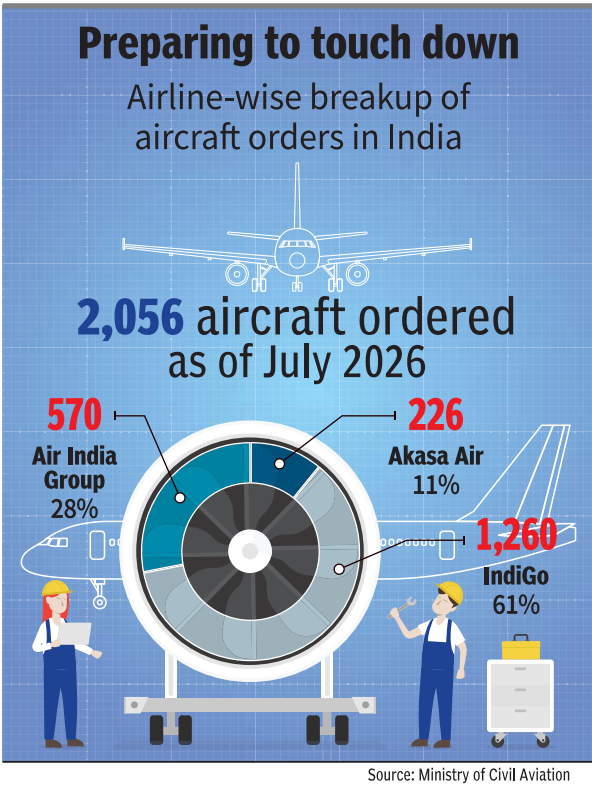
Tata Steel says PIRONutri38 shows 100 per cent solubility under simulated gastric conditions (pH 1 in dilute hydrochloric acid) within 30 minutes, indicating that the elemental iron is readily released in such an environment.

The company also says the powder

has favourable sensory properties. In consumer evaluations, more than 80 per cent of respondents rated it above 7 on a scale of 1 to 9 for parameters including appearance, taste, aroma, colour, texture, flavour and overall palatability. The last point matters because nutrition products often fail not because the science is wrong, but because people do not like consuming them. Importantly, PIRONutri38 has been evaluated by a reputed national nutrition research institution for its suitability as an iron supplement ingredient.

However, Tata Steel is not getting into the business of making edible steel. It will license the technology to any food or nutrition company and stay content with the higher revenue from the sale of its iron powder.

A steel plant may appear to be an unlikely place for discovering a solution to iron deficiency. But perhaps, that is the point. In a world increasingly obsessed with circular economy, waste from one process could become raw material for another.



GLOBAL BYTES.

West Asia-Latin America aviation pact

Abra Group, a leading air transportation company across Latin America, and Etihad Airways have established a partnership to strengthen connectivity between Latin America, West Asia and key global markets. The MoU is a framework for long-term collaboration across Abra's airlines Avianca, GOL and Wamos Air, connecting Latin America, West Asia and the rest of Asia through complementary networks. The partnership includes immediate initiatives spanning network development, loyalty programmes, aircraft leasing and ACMI (aircraft, crew, maintenance and insurance) operations, according to a media release.

Counting carbon collectively

What was the carbon dioxide impact of your last flight? Unfortunately, the answer may depend on whom you ask. That is why IATA is advocating for a globally standardised approach to emissions reporting. IATA's CO2 Connect emissions calculator uses data from 110 airlines, which monitor and record every drop of fuel used by their aircraft. Unfortunately, Europe is moving in a direction that creates fragmentation, an unnecessary administrative burden and additional costs for airlines, says IATA. "Collaboration could pave the way for a standardised approach by regulators globally," said Michael Schneider, IATA's Assistant Director of Sustainability Programmes.

Multi-lane, free-flowing highways

Fee plazas for which contracts have been awarded for barrier-less tolling — vehicle users shall be charged without having to stop, slow down or stay in a given lane



Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	Jul 9	Jul 23	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,76,000	1,75,000	-0.57
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,59,000	1,60,000	0.63
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,80,000	1,79,000	-0.56
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,96,000	1,97,000	0.51
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	2,03,000	2,04,000	0.49
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,19,000	2,20,000	0.45
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,25,000	2,26,000	0.44
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,69,000	1,70,000	0.59
Delhi-Raipur-Delhi	1,66,000	1,65,000	-0.61
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,45,000	1,44,000	-0.69
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,75,000	1,73,000	-1.16
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	2,04,000	2,01,000	-1.49
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	2,02,000	2,03,000	0.49
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,15,000	2,14,000	-0.47
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,16,000	2,15,000	-0.47
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,46,000	1,47,000	0.68
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,84,000	2,85,000	0.35
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,86,000	2,85,000	-0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,66,000	1,67,000	0.60
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,58,000	1,60,000	1.25
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,48,000	1,48,000	0.00
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	1,03,000	1,05,000	1.90
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,66,000	1,65,000	-0.61
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,57,000	1,56,000	-0.64
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,16,000	1,17,000	0.85
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	70,000	72,000	2.78
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	86,000	85,000	-1.18
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	69,000	70,000	1.43

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

CONTRASTING TAKE-OFFS

Greenfield airports: Diverging paths

PROGRESS REPORT. As Andhra Pradesh readies to add a new airport, why Tamil Nadu's effort is stuck at the starting block

T E Raja Simhan

With the greenfield Bhogapuram airport, near Visakhapatnam, set to be inaugurated on August 1 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, comparisons have again surfaced between Andhra Pradesh's flagship aviation project and the proposed Parandur airport, near Chennai.

While both airports in southern India were conceived to meet the rising demand for aviation services, their timelines have diverged sharply because of the nature of the land identified for acquisition and the challenges that followed.

Bhogapuram, which has secured its aerodrome licence and is ready for commercial operations, received the site clearance from the Centre in 2016. The Andhra Pradesh government awarded the concession to GMR Airports in 2020, the foundation stone was laid in May 2023, and the construction was completed in about three years.

Parandur, in contrast, remains in the pre-construction stage despite the then Tamil Nadu government deciding on the site in 2022 and receiving the Centre's in-principle approval in 2023. The State is yet to complete land acquisition, appoint a developer or commence construction.

The new government, headed by Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam, is going slow on the project as its leader and Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay had supported the villagers of Parandur in opposing the greenfield project. This was also a stepping stone for his entry into politics.

HURDLES ON LAND

The Bhogapuram site largely comprises dry agricultural land, government land and scrubland with fewer habitations, making land acquisition primarily an exercise in compensation and rehabilitation.

At Parandur, on the other hand, at stake are nearly 5,000 acres of fertile irrigated farmland, wetlands and irrigation tanks spread across 13 villages. The project has faced sustained opposition from locals over the looming loss of multi-crop agricultural land, the disruption of irrigation systems and the ecological role of the interconnected wetlands that serve as flood buffers.

The complexity inherent in acquiring environmentally sensitive and densely



READY FOR BUSINESS. Bhogapuram international airport, near Visakhapatnam KR DEEPAK

Bhogapuram and Parandur airport projects: A timeline

Airport project	Bhogapuram (Andhra Pradesh)	Parandur (Tamil Nadu)
Site selection	2015-16	2022
Centre's in-principle approval	2016	2023
Land acquisition	Completed; predominantly dry agricultural and government land with limited displacement	Ongoing, with sustained local opposition; nearly 4,970 acres of fertile farmland, wetlands and 13 villages
Developer selection	GMR Airports (appointed in 2020)	Yet to be decided
Financial closure	Achieved before construction	Pending
Foundation stone laying	May 2023	Awaited
Construction	May 2023-26	None
Current status	Inauguration on August 1	Land acquisition stage

cultivated land has slowed the project.

Officials familiar with both projects emphasised that it was like "comparing apples and oranges", given the vastly different land acquisition challenges. However, they acknowledged that the two projects continue to be viewed as benchmarks for infrastructure execution in southern India.

J Krishnan, partner at S Natesa Iyer Logistics LLP, said Andhra Pradesh's approach to site selection had helped it avoid controversies right from the early stage.

"The Andhra Pradesh government's initial search and identification of the air-

port land was methodical and the search committee eschewed any controversy likely to surface by interested groups. This ensured the project did not face major implementation delays," he said.

LOSS OF BUSINESS

Parandur has attracted environmental and livelihood concerns from day one, he pointed out. "The dense industrial and urban activity around Chennai has made identifying a new airport site particularly challenging. Differences are bound to surface even if alternative locations are identified," he added.

Industry stakeholders also stressed the

REALISTIC PLANNING

Demand-led port expansion



B SWAMINATHAN

India's maritime sector has experienced remarkable growth in recent years as the country seeks to strengthen its role in global manufacturing, trade and logistics networks. Government initiatives such as Sagarmala and Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision (MAKV) 2047 aim to expand port capacity, improve multimodal connectivity, promote coastal shipping and reduce logistics costs. Major investments are being made in new berths, deeper draughts, mechanised cargo handling, freight corridors, logistics parks, inland transport and digital infrastructure to create an integrated maritime and logistics ecosystem.

However, infrastructure expansion alone cannot ensure sustainable development. Port capacity must be aligned with realistic cargo demand projections. Since port projects involve substantial capital investment and a long gestation period, inaccurate forecasting can result in significant operational and financial inefficiencies. Excess capacity leads to underutilised terminals and idle equipment, and poor returns on investment. As global trade patterns and domestic economic conditions continue to evolve,

port planning is becoming increasingly complex.

OPERATIONAL EFFICIENCY

In port planning, the concept of 'highest efficient attainable throughput' (HEAT) refers to the maximum cargo volume a port can handle efficiently without causing significant congestion. As traffic nears this threshold, berth occupancy rises, vessel turnaround slows, storage yards become congested and cargo-handling equipment comes under pressure. Beyond this level, efficiency declines quickly, leading to higher logistics costs, supply chain disruptions and reduced competitiveness.

To sustain efficiency, ports require timely capacity augmentation, operational modernisation, improved hinterland connectivity and digital integration. While infrastructure expansion remains important, equal emphasis must be placed on optimising existing assets and improving operational performance.

India's major and non-major ports are already showing signs of capacity imbalance. As of March this year, the country's ports had a combined handling capacity of nearly 2,762 million tonnes, while actual cargo traffic was about 1,668 million tonnes, reflecting around 60 per cent utilisation. International port planning practices, including guidance from the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development, gener-

ally consider around 70 per cent utilisation as efficient, as this balances flexibility with congestion control.

Since the 1970s, the UNCTAD has encouraged ports to maximise operational efficiency and optimise existing infrastructure before undertaking largescale expansion. The MAKV 2047 envisages creating nearly 10,000 million tonnes of port handling capacity by 2047, whereas the projected cargo traffic, assuming annual growth of about 6 per cent, is estimated at only 5,630 million tonnes. This suggests that the planned capacity of around 8,000 million tonnes would adequately meet future demand, highlighting the need for demand-driven infrastructure planning.

Rising competition among ports on the eastern and western coastlines, particularly with the rapid expansion of private ports, has led to overlapping infrastructure development and dispersed cargo movement. Future port development should be guided by realistic demand forecasting, integrated logistics planning and continuous market assessment.

This approach will improve competitiveness, optimise investments, strengthen supply chain resilience and ensure the long-term financial sustainability of India's maritime sector.

The writer is a retired associate professor of the Indian Maritime University—Chennai Campus. Views are personal



OPTIMISING USAGE. Cargo handling capacity must balance flexibility with congestion control B JOTHI RAMALINGAM

MARITIME BOOST

Act II for new AP ports



BIGGER AIM. Machilipatnam port awaits expansion GN RAO

G Naga Sridhar

Andhra Pradesh's port economy is poised for a major transformation. Even as the first phase of work on three greenfield ports nears completion, the State government is laying the ground for the next growth wave by committing ₹1,638.52 crore to acquire 6,248.54 acres for phase-II expansion.

The government has given administrative nod for land acquisition for the Ramayapatnam, Mulapeta and Machilipatnam ports, following directions from Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, said Investments and Infrastructure Minister BC Janardhan Reddy.

Of the total allocation, ₹851 crore has been earmarked for acquiring 2,924.45 acres for the second phase of Ramayapatnam port.

The government has sanctioned ₹440.52 crore for acquiring 1,903.39 acres for the expansion of Mulapeta port. The proposed works will also cover the acquisition of salt lands and the implementation of rehabilitation and resettlement measures at Mulapeta.

For the second phase of expansion at Machilipatnam port, the government has approved the acquisition of 1,420.70 acres at a cost of ₹347 crore.

The approvals are expected to accelerate the expansion of the greenfield ports and strengthen Andhra Pradesh's maritime infrastructure.

With three of the five greenfield ports under construction expected to become operational within six months, the State's maritime capacity is set to grow significantly.

Cargo-handling capacity is expected to increase by more than 50 per cent — from 195 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) to 286 MTPA, according to official data.

"With the commencement of phase II development of the upcoming ports, the next five years will witness a major leap in port-based logistics in the State," a senior government official said.

As part of its maritime growth strategy, the State aims to achieve an optimal port capacity utilisation of 75 per cent by 2030 and cut vessel turnaround time to under 15 hours, thereby improving operational efficiency and competitiveness.

The State government recently proposed a partnership with South Korean maritime equipment manufacturers to invest in the upcoming Dugarajapatnam shipbuilding cluster, which is jointly developed by the Andhra Pradesh Maritime Board (APMB) and the Visakhapatnam Port Authority.

MY FIVE.

MANISH GUPTA
Chairman and CEO, Indegene



No-call mornings, yoga, and unwinding with books and spies

- 1 No calls: My days start with chai, taking in the morning stillness and freshness — free from work, no emails or calls.
- 2 Walks: A 60-minute brisk walk or an hour of lyengar yoga every morning is non-negotiable. The rigour of exercise fills me with energy for everything the day has in store. I follow this up with 10-15 minutes of meditation to clear thoughts and calm me down before work.
- 3 Learning: The infamous Bengaluru traffic means I spend a lot of time in the car to get to office every day! I fill this time productively — listening to podcasts, YouTube videos and audiobooks on various topics. It keeps me mentally agile — I draw connections between work, life and all the new things I learn, which ends up helping in the most unexpected situations!
- 4 Eat together: My family eats dinner together every day. Our weekend dinners often extend to an hour or two — with good food, laughter and a large dose and variety of vegetables in our meals.
- 5 Intrigue: I am a fan of action movies, thriller TV shows. I unwind by watching them — a break from the hustle of everyday life into the realm of the fascinating lives of secret agents and spies. Sometimes a good book quietyens the mind.

CAPSULE.

Road crashes kill 1.16 million

Despite the addition of more than one billion motor vehicles to the world's roads, the global rate of road traffic deaths declined by



21 per cent between 2011 and 2025, according to new data released by the World Health Organization (WHO). The world has experienced profound changes in road traffic during this time, with the emergence of new modes of transport and a sharp rise in motorcycle use. At the same time, road traffic crashes claimed 1.16 million lives in 2025, it added. Road traffic injuries remain the leading cause of death among children and youth aged 5-29. The WHO data comes as global leaders adopt a new United Nations General Assembly progress declaration on road safety to boost global action to meet the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) target of 50 per cent reduction in road deaths and serious injuries by 2030, compared with the levels in 2021. "This progress shows that change is possible when countries invest in safe road systems," said WHO Director-General Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus.

COMING UP.

Freeing up hepatitis care

World Hepatitis Day is observed on July 28 every year to raise awareness on viral hepatitis, an inflammation of the liver that causes severe liver disease and liver cancer. This year's theme, 'Hepatitis: Let's break it down', is a call to remove the barriers between people and the services that can save their lives, the World Health Organization said. The tools needed to eliminate viral hepatitis already exist, including vaccines and lifelong therapies. And yet, millions remain undiagnosed or unable to access care due to stigma, health system gaps and persistent inequalities.

GRIM REMINDER

RG Kar and after: Unfinished task of keeping hospitals safe

ELUSIVE CURE. Two years after a medic's gruesome murder, healthcare workers remain vulnerable

PT Jyothi Datta

A recent video showing a political representative in an altercation with medical staff, including seemingly raising his hand on a female doctor, at a hospital in Dombivli, near Mumbai, sparked widespread outrage, especially among the country's medical fraternity. The incident — barely two years after a young trainee doctor was allegedly raped and killed at the RG Kar Hospital in Kolkata — serves as a grim reminder of the violence doctors continue to face. The shocking crime pushed doctors to demand measures to make hospitals a safe zone, including deployment of security personnel and CCTVs, and a Central Act to safeguard medical staff against violence.

And yet, multiple incidents of assaults on doctors in the ensuing months, including one as recently as in June at a hospital in Rajasthan and in July at Dombivli, have shown that the needle has not moved much when it comes to ensuring the personal safety of doctors, nurses and other medical staff against a rising tide of violence from attendants of patients. Vinita (name changed on request), a resident doctor at a government medical college hospital, says doctors face the ire of the people accompanying patients for reasons that may be beyond their control. For example, she says, at any point there may be two or three doctors at the hospital's emergency room, which is overloaded with about 50 people. When doctors prioritise those needing immediate attention, it attracts complaints from those who may have arrived earlier with minor injuries, she explains. "At such times we are subjected to verbal abuse," she says,



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adding that they call the security guards for help.

FEMINISATION OF STAFF Dr RV Asokan, former President of the Indian Medical Association (IMA), points out that the profession is "feminising" — about 60 per cent of the doctors in the country are women. Hospitals need to become sensitive and safe workplaces for them, he says, adding that nothing really has changed on the ground.

Often doctors are blamed for administrative shortcomings, such as the absence of a specific facility needed to treat a particular condition, he says. In the Dombivli Shastrinagar Municipal Hospital case, for instance, reports indicate that a pregnant lady had been advised to approach another government hospital for a neonatal ICU facility on a day Mumbai witnessed heavy rain. The corporator accused of the assault, whose bail

has since been cancelled by the Bombay High Court, told mediapersons that he stepped into the picture to ensure the pregnant lady got the necessary care. He denied attacking the female doctor, and sought to clarify that he was merely knocking the phone out of her hand. Two of the doctors who bore the brunt of the attack have since resigned, fearing for their safety, according to media reports.

SAFE ZONES

Sometimes, even the act of communicating a difficult situation to a patient's family turns into a tense moment, says a female doctor, adding that it calls for handling the situation with sensitivity, empathy and calm nerves. This is where clinical training matters, and it can come not from textbooks but from ward rounds, says Asokan. The more patients young doctors see, the better they become at handling difficult situations and communicating bad news to families, he says. "The art of medicine is learnt at the bedside," he says. The "inhuman" workload on resident doctors — over 100 hours at times — adds to their stress. This certainly can be regulated, he adds.

Indranil Deshmukh, National Secretary of the IMA Junior Doctors Network, reminds authorities about their commitment to making hospitals "safe zones". There are incidents of violence against healthcare practitioners every other day, he says, calling for a Central Act to provide uniform protection to medical staff across the country, fast-track courts and clear penalties for those attacking hospital staff and infrastructure.

While hospitals in cities and metros may be able to install CCTVs for their protection, he says there is a need to also ensure a safe working environment for healthcare practitioners at primary health centres located in remote areas.

FROM THE REGULATOR

Australia says 'no' to nicotine pouches

New regulations are in place across Australia to restrict access to nicotine pouches to protect public health, said the country's Therapeutic Goods Administration. The changes follow consultations with stakeholders and reflect concerns over the health risks associated with emerging nicotine products, particularly their potential appeal to young people and the increased risk of nicotine dependence. From July 24, people can no longer import nicotine pouches through the Personal Importation Scheme nor access them through the Special Access Scheme or Authorised Prescriber Scheme nor have them compounded by pharmacists.

The Personal Importation Scheme allowed individuals to import therapeutic goods for personal use under certain conditions. The Special Access Scheme and Authorised Prescriber Scheme enabled health practitioners to prescribe unapproved therapeutic goods to patients when the use is clinically justified. Pharmacists and certain other healthcare practitioners could compound medicines for individual patients when an approved medicine is not suitable. Under the new rule, nicotine pouches cannot be compounded for individual patient use.



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Prof Anthony Lawler, Deputy Secretary of the Department of health, disability and ageing, and head of TGA, said, "These changes respond to growing public health concern about nicotine pouches and their increasing availability in the Australian market. They strengthen the ability of the TGA and its partner agencies to combat the unlawful importation, advertising and supply of nicotine pouches, while ensuring Australians have access to safe, approved and evidence-based options to quit smoking and manage nicotine dependence."

Nicotine is highly addictive, and its use during adolescence can affect brain development and increase the risk of ongoing dependence. There is limited evidence that nicotine pouches help people quit smoking or manage nicotine dependence, and their full health impacts remain unknown. They may pose significant health risks, including high or inconsistent nicotine content, potential contaminants and misleading labelling.

Australians have access to nicotine replacement therapies such as patches, gum and lozenges, as well as medicines where clinically appropriate.

Source: TGA

LENS ON HEALTH



RAGING WORRIES. Healthcare workers light a bonfire as they protest outside the Elikyia Ebola Treatment Centre to demand payment of pending wage benefits after a visit by Prime Minister Judith Suminwa Tuluka, as authorities intensify efforts to contain the Ebola outbreak involving the Bundibugyo strain, in Bunia, Democratic Republic of Congo REUTERS

NFHS-6 flags regional shifts in healthcare needs

BY INVITATION



POONAM MUTTREJA

On May 29, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare released the much-awaited sixth round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6). The 'national' data, in reality, tells the story of many regions that are increasingly diverging in ways that make governance under one policy framework untenable.

India's total fertility rate (TFR) stands at 2, below the replacement level of 2.1 and unchanged from the previous round of the survey about five years ago. But this story of stability seems inaccurate once you start reading past the national average.

Urban India's TFR is 1.6, while for rural India it is 2.1; Bihar continues to lead among states, with a TFR of 2.7. At the same time, states like Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Kerala have been below replacement level for decades.

Some regions still require investment in reproductive health, contraception, girls' education and child marriage prevention. Others need to prepare for ageing populations, care systems, changing labour markets and low fertility. A one-size-fits-all population policy is out of date.

The same pattern recurs across reproductive health indicators. The national unmet need for family planning has declined marginally from 9.4 per cent in NFHS-5 to 8.5 per cent in NFHS-6. But this aggregate hides serious State-level gaps. Meghalaya records unmet need at 21 per cent, Bihar 14.4 per cent, Jharkhand 12.6 per cent and Uttar Pradesh 10.8 per cent. Behind these numbers are millions of women who want to delay or avoid pregnancy but are unable to use contraception.

The method mix also remains highly gendered. Female sterilisation continues to dominate contraception, while male sterilisation remains negligible at 0.5 per cent. Andhra Pradesh, for instance, has a female sterilisation rate of 69.5 per cent. This should force us to ask whether high contraceptive prevalence truly reflects choice or whether the burden of family planning continues to fall overwhelmingly on women.



SKewed BURDEN. Female sterilisation dominates family planning

NFHS-6 also reminds us that fertility cannot be separated from adolescent health and gender inequality. Child marriage has declined nationally, but 20.1 per cent of women aged 20-24 were married before 18. In West Bengal, Bihar and Tripura, more than one in three young women were married before adulthood. Adolescent motherhood remains virtually unchanged nationally at 6.7 per cent and is far higher in States such as Tripura, West Bengal, Jharkhand and Bihar.

The policy lesson from NFHS-6 is clear — India must move from national templates to geography-specific, life-cycle-based and women-centred health planning. High-fertility rural regions need improved reproductive health services, adolescent health programmes, contraception access and action against child marriage. Low-fertility and ageing regions need care infrastructure, active ageing and geriatric health services, childcare, women's workforce support and social protection.

Above all, India must place women's agency at the centre. Health policy cannot simply count births, contraceptive use or institutional deliveries. It must ask whether women have the power to make informed decisions about marriage, contraception, childbirth, healthcare and work.

NFHS-6 shows there is no single India. Our health policy must recognise that reality. The future lies not in population panic or national averages, but in local evidence, women's rights and health systems that respond to the lives people actually lead.

The writer is Executive Director, Population Foundation of India. Views are personal

PMOS: A name change that validates women's concerns

Those coping with the symptoms need to be assured it's a complex metabolic-hormonal condition deserving attention



DAMINI GROVER

Women with polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS) have heard the same things for years: "Just lose weight", "handle your stress" or "take the pill".

PCOS is now a recognised condition, yet many women continue to suffer in silence, not just physically but also emotionally and psychologically.

Following the renaming of PCOS to poly metabolic ovary syndrome (PMOS), there was debate over the need for the name change. I believe this conversation is far more important than people realise, even from a mental health perspective.

The usage PCOS often reduces the condition to an ovarian, reproductive issue. But for many women, it is about so much more than irregular periods or cysts. It affects mood, energy, self-worth, body image, stress response,



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eating patterns, sleep and sometimes even a woman's sense of self and trust in her own body — issues we see in therapy rooms every day.

The PMOS terminology recognises what women have been dealing with for years — this condition is metabolic, hormonal, inflammatory and systemic, not just ovarian. And that shift in understanding is definitely psychologically validating as well.

In my experience as a woman living with PCOS and a therapist, I see women carrying layers of emotional exhaustion that are repeatedly minim-

ised while coping with chronic fatigue, brain fog, weight changes, bloating, mood fluctuations, sleep disruption, hair loss, acne, anxiety, food cravings and body image concerns. Many don't even know that these experiences may be related. Instead, they internalise them as "I am lazy", "I'm not disciplined", "Why can't I move my body?", "Why am I so emotional?" or "Why is everyone else coping better than me?"

This is where mental health and hormonal health become deeply intertwined, and most people don't know about it. When a woman's body is unpredictable, exhausted, inflamed or constantly "off", it takes a psychological toll. Research consistently shows that women with PCOS have higher rates of anxiety, depression, eating disorders and body image distress. Many describe it as a constant battle with their own bodies and yet they continue to work, care for others and appear socially while silently battling symptoms that others cannot see. They are often told, "You looked fine yesterday", "You think too much", "Everyone gets tired" or "You just need more motivation".

What is overlooked is that persist-

ent hormonal and metabolic dysregulation affects not only the body but also emotional regulation, stress tolerance, concentration, motivation and mood.

Perhaps the PMOS conversation is psychologically helpful because it expands the story. It tells women this isn't "just periods", "just weight" or a personal failure. It is a complex metabolic-hormonal condition that deserves attention. Simply understanding that "I'm not imagining my exhaustion", "My mood swings are not me being dramatic" or "My body is not betraying me on purpose" can reduce shame and make healing more compassionate.

Most importantly, the conversation needs to move away from appearance-based narratives. Many women with PCOS are not just dealing with symptoms but also self-criticism every day. This is why language matters. A better understanding of conditions like PMOS can support mental health, not because a name changes reality but because being understood certainly can.

The writer is the founder of I'M Powered centre for counselling and well-being

QUICKLY.

Iran to halt attacks if US maintains pause

Dubai/Washington: Iran will halt its own attacks as long as the US maintains its latest pause on air strikes, a senior Iranian official told *Reuters* on Sunday, after US President Donald Trump abruptly called off his 13 nights of intensifying air strikes on Iran late on Friday to allow more time for diplomatic discussions. No US attacks were reported on Saturday or Sunday as well. Iran, which had been following each night of US attacks with its own strikes on neighbouring countries that host US bases, has also so far held fire for two days. The US ambassador to the United Nations, Mike Waltz, told *Fox News* on Sunday that Trump had decided to pause US attacks to allow more time for diplomacy. “He’s giving talks some space, he’s giving it a little bit of room,” said Waltz, without providing further details. *REUTERS*

Nilekani to head task force on NTA reforms: PM

EXAM SCRUTINY. Announcement comes amid scrutiny of agency following a series of controversies over competitive examinations in recent years

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the constitution of a high-power task force headed by technology expert Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms for the National Testing Agency (NTA), with a focus on overhauling the examination system through technology and structural changes. The announcement comes amid sustained scrutiny of the NTA following a series of controversies over competitive examinations in recent years. In a message on social media platform X, the PM said: “Friends, for the future of the students, the Indian government is taking many steps continuously. The people who played with the

future of the students, they are rotting in the jails. We have already made a fast track court. Even in the Parliament tomorrow, we are moving forward with the implementation of new laws. But we have to think about the future. We have to make sure that our exam procedures are safe. We have to make sure that our exam procedures are transparent. We have to make sure that most of the technology is used in our exam procedures. With all these things in mind, under the leadership of the world-famous technology expert Nandan Nilekani, we have decided to form a high-power task force which will focus on examination reform. And soon, the task of ensuring the reliability of upcoming exams will be done on the basis of the report of the task force,” he added.



PM Narendra Modi

According to the details shared by the government, the multidisciplinary panel will recommend reforms to revamp the NTA’s examination processes, particularly from a technology perspective, while also suggesting structural changes to strengthen the integrity and efficiency of the testing system.

TASK FORCE

- **Nandan Nilekani**, architect of Aadhaar
- **S Somanath**, former ISRO Chairman
- **Tapan Deka**, former Intelligence Bureau Director
- **V Kamakoti**, IIT (Madras) Director
- **Anita Karwal**, former Education Secretary
- **Amrit Lal Meena**, logistics expert

The task force will be chaired by Nandan Nilekani, Co-founder of Infosys and the architect of Aadhaar. It will include former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) Chairman S Somanath, former Intelligence Bureau Director Tapan Deka, Indian Institute of Technology-Madras Director V Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert and former civil servant Amrit Lal Meena.

The inclusion of experts from technology, education,

intelligence, space research and logistics signals the government’s attempt to address multiple aspects of examination management, including digital infrastructure, cybersecurity, operational planning and governance.

The announcement follows months of debate over the credibility of national entrance examinations conducted by the NTA.

Allegations of paper leaks, irregularities and technical glitches in examinations such as NEET-UG triggered nationwide protests and

legal challenges, prompting the Centre to promise a comprehensive overhaul.

INSTITUTIONAL REFORMS

The newly constituted panel is expected to examine ways to improve the security, transparency and robustness of examinations through technological interventions while recommending institutional reforms for the NTA.

Meanwhile, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday assumed additional charge of the Ministry of Education and said that he had begun reviewing the Ministry’s functioning by holding detailed meetings with senior officials.

Speaking to reporters after taking charge, Joshi said that he was familiarising himself with the Ministry’s work before making any de-

cisions. “I have taken charge of the Ministry. I am learning about the Ministry and the decisions I have to take as the Minister. I am getting to understand the Ministry from 11 am till 3 pm in the evening. I also spoke with the officials in detail. This is a big department. I will speak in detail after understanding its functioning,” he said.

Later in the day, Joshi chaired a review meeting of the Ministry, where he took stock of the implementation of various schemes and on-going initiatives.

Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary also attended the meeting.

Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Vineet Joshi, and Secretary, Department of School Education and Literacy, TK Anil Kumar, along with senior officers of the Ministry, were present at the review meeting.

India-US trade talks likely to gather pace only after Section 301 excess capacity investigations

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA) negotiations are unlikely to see meaningful progress until the US concludes its pending Section 301 investigations into alleged structural excess capacity even though Washington has already announced the outcome of its separate forced labour probe, sources said.

The outcome of the excess capacity investigations is expected to have a greater bearing on the contours of the trade agreement as it could result in additional trade measures, including higher tariffs, on a wide range of products such as steel, auto-

mobiles, textiles, medical devices, solar panels and petrochemicals, shaping the overall negotiating environment between the two countries.

“The forced labour investigation has provided some clarity on the emerging US trade regime, but it is only one part of the larger Section 301 exercise. The excess capacity investigations are likely to have much broader implications for trade flows and market access. Meaningful movement in the BTA is expected only after those findings are out,” a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

BIGGER CONCERN

Last week, the US announced an additional 10 per



cent tariff on imports from India under its new Section 301 forced labour regime.

The additional forced labour tariffs would be imposed on about 55 per cent of India’s exports as an estimated 45 per cent of exports fall under various exempted categories, according to the Indian government’s calculations.

The bigger concern, however, is that India and 15 other countries are awaiting the outcome of the investigations into alleged excess capacities in several sectors, as the findings could result in further trade actions or tariffs affecting a broader range of imports. Others being investigated include China, the EU, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico and Japan.

EXCESS CAPACITY

“Unless the Section 301 tariffs on excess capacity are decided, there can be no further progress on India-US BTA. Let’s wait for final decision on 301 excess capacity

tariffs,” pointed out Pankaj Chadha, Chairman, EEPIC India. Engineering goods, including steel and automobile products, are among the target products in the excess capacity investigations.

As per the USTR notification on the Section 301 excess capacity investigations, “India’s global goods trade surplus sectors include textiles, health, construction goods and automotive goods. For example, evidence suggests the solar module sector is plagued by excess capacity, including that India’s current module manufacturing is nearly triple the annual domestic demand. India also has created significant excess capacity in petrochemicals, steel and other industries.”

Retailers wary as memory prices push smartphones out of customer’s reach

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai



Rising memory costs and wary consumer trends in the first half of 2026 have sparked fears of a muted festive season in 2026 as half of the retailers in a recent market survey anticipate a decline in sales.

While higher per-phone prices are holding up rupee turnover, retailers worry about survival by December 2026.

Following reports of cautious purchases by customers in the face of rising memory costs, the All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA) and Techarc market research found that 49 per cent of the 1,126 retailers interviewed had already reported a business decline in the first six months of the calendar year. 61 per cent retailers said they sold fewer smartphone units between January and June 2026 than during the same period in 2025.

Conversations with retailers in Mumbai revealed that while the foothall of smartphone customers remains unchanged, the enthusiasm to buy the devices has lessened compared to last year. This trend is common across both small and large retailers.

“Memory costs have pushed up smartphone prices but customers do not want to move beyond their budget range. Some look for discounts or alternative options, while others leave without making a purchase,” said a Vijay Sales employee in Thane, speaking on the condition of anonymity.

Another local retailer added that customers were walking out of the shop without making a purchase. When asked about festive season expectations, both retailers adopted a wait-and-watch approach.

“This report confirms

what many of us have felt at the counter through the first half of 2026: Rising memory and component costs are pushing phone prices beyond what our customers can afford, and it is volume—the number of handsets we sell—that is quietly bearing the brunt, even where rupee turnover appears steady,” said Kailash Lakhyani, Founding Chairman, All India Mobile Retailers Association (AIMRA), in the *Retailer Pulse* report.

Overall, 50 per cent of retailers worry about festive season sales.

Also, 48 per cent of retailers are worried that their business will not survive until the end of 2026. This is concerning given that retailers are expected to be the final influence on purchase decisions amidst current price uncertainties, as per Counterpoint Research.

CHANGING LEVERS

While smartphone sales declined in terms of volume, purchase value held ground with 43.7 per cent reporting higher value, as per the *Retailer Pulse* report.

In response to this trend, brands are now realigning their portfolio towards higher-value products rather than entry-level phones, industry sources told *businessline*.

This means that the worst of the sales decline will be borne by retailers operating in the base-to-mid price smartphone segment. Already, 81 per cent of retailers expect the ₹10,000–

30,000 mass market to bear the most pressure in H2, according to the report. The sub-₹1 crore and single independent outlets show the highest survival risk and the least value cushion.

Chains and larger stores are weathering the situation better, largely due to the growing dependence on smartphones, as per Counterpoint Research.

“Consumers’ dependence on smartphones has grown significantly, leading to a clearer understanding of the features and experiences they value. Against this backdrop, price increases are driving shifts in consumer purchase plans, creating opportunities for brands with strong pull, especially in the mid-to-premium segment. Brands offering a balanced portfolio across adjacent price bands are likely to benefit from this movement,” said Arushi Chawla, Senior Analyst, Counterpoint Research, in its recent report.

The research firm reported that 54 per cent of smartphone buyers refused to stretch their budget for smartphone purchases, with 25 per cent of consumers opting to delay their purchases. The remaining 29 per cent consumers looked for alternative solutions like refurbished devices within the planned budget.

While Counterpoint Research stressed that the largest cohort of 46 per cent of consumers are willing to stretch their budget within the next six months for preferred smartphones, a combined reading with the retailer report and the counterpoint findings show that the willingness has failed to translate into actual purchases so far.

Faced with the possibility of a muted festive season, 53 per cent of the retailers have asked that the government reduce the GST on smartphones as well as the import duty.

CBDT issues detailed crypto reporting norms, tightening tax oversight without changing levy

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi



The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has issued a comprehensive guidance note, laying down reporting obligations for crypto exchanges and other intermediaries, marking a significant step towards bringing virtual digital asset (VDA) transactions under a more structured tax reporting framework.

The move comes shortly after the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance urged the government to examine the need for a statutory and regulatory framework for VDAs.

“The note describes the scope of the crypto assets and intermediaries that are covered, the basis on which a

service provider is required to report, the identification of reportable persons, the due diligence procedures to be followed and the requirements and procedure for furnishing the report,” said Prasenjit Singh, Member, CBDT, in the introductory note of the 198-page document.

Cryptos in India are neither legal nor illegal, though its transaction at-

tracts tax deducted at source (TDS) and profits attract 30 per cent interest tax under the mechanism of taxation on VDA, which also includes NFT and similar products but not CBDCs.

While the responsibility of TDS lies with crypto exchanges and intermediaries that facilitate the transaction, profit must be reported by the recipient. There is no change in this entire structure, but the reporting has been further streamlined.

A STRUCTURAL SHIFT

According to Punit Agarwal, Founder and CEO of KoinX, for the industry, this is a structural shift. Crypto platforms must evolve from being purely transaction infrastructure to becoming compliance infrastructure, with robust systems for tax

residency determination, customer due diligence, transaction classification and standardised reporting.

“This will accelerate investment in RegTech and tax technology, and platforms that invest early in strong tax reporting and compliance capabilities will be best positioned as more jurisdictions begin exchanging crypto tax information,” he said, while adding that for investors the message is equally clear.

“While CARF doesn’t impose any new taxes, it significantly raises the global standard for transparency,” he said.

Experts said the guidelines can be summed up in four broad aspects. First, it aims for greater transparency. This will be possible as crypto transactions will increasingly come

within the ambit of structured reporting and information exchange like the existing FATCA and common reporting standard framework. The second is better visibility for tax authorities. The objective is to bridge the information gap that existed because crypto assets could be transferred or held outside the traditional financial system. The third is global alignment. India is aligning its reporting standards with internationally accepted OECD norms, thereby strengthening cross-border exchange of crypto transaction information. And fourth, there is no change in taxability.

The note is procedural in nature and should not be interpreted as introducing a new tax or altering the existing taxation framework.

Vanishing spirit: Why has Old Monk rum gone missing from liquor shelves across Maharashtra?

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Rajesh Chhabria, 35, a Nagpur banker, enjoys Glenfiddich and Singleton single malts. But when the monsoon arrives, he reaches for Old Monk.

At a recent get-together, friends braved the rain to join him for hot kebabs, onion pakoras and India’s best-known dark rum. But his home bar had no Old

Delays in bottling or dispatches can leave one market short without affecting another

Monk to offer. He went looking for a bottle, but shops across Nagpur had no stock or said supplies were irregular. Local bars offered Old Monk by the peg but refused takeaway bottles.

SEASONAL DEMAND

Chhabria called tipplers in Pune, Akola and Mumbai but the answer was the same: supplies of the smiling monk on the label, affectionately known as the ‘Budha Sadhu’, have become irregular across Maharashtra. What began as one con-

sumer’s search for his favourite monsoon drink is emerging as a wider supply squeeze.

Retailers and distributors say Old Monk has become increasingly difficult to replenish just as seasonal demand accelerates, raising questions over whether ethanol diversion, bottling constraints or distribution bottlenecks are disrupting supplies of one of India’s most enduring liquor brands.

IS ETHANOL TO BLAME ?

That question is now echoing through liquor stores and distribution warehouses across Maharashtra. Industry executives say ethanol diversion alone does not explain the shortage.

While the Centre’s ethanol-blending programme has increased demand for molasses-based feedstock,

the current crunch appears to reflect a perfect storm, a predictable monsoon demand surge colliding with bottling and dispatch constraints at facilities serving western India, including the Khopoli unit, along with State excise approvals, transport permits and distributor allocations.

Because alcohol is regulated State by State, delays in bottling or dispatches can leave one market short without affecting another.

If ethanol were the primary reason, trade executives argue, competing dark rum brands would also be disappearing from the shelves.

Instead, the shortage appears largely confined to Old Monk, pointing to a brand-specific supply-chain issue, rather than an industry-wide shortage of rum.

TCPL pinning growth on new-age portfolio as tea and salt business remains steady, says CEO

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru



Sunil D'Souza, Managing Director and CEO, Tata Consumer Products Ltd

Tata Consumer Products Ltd (TCPL) is increasingly leaning on its fast-growing portfolio of newer businesses to power its next phase of growth, as its legacy tea and salt categories settle into a mature growth trajectory.

The company said businesses such as Tata Sampann, Capital Foods, Organic India and ready-to-drink (RTD) beverages will continue to underpin double-digit revenue growth, with the management maintaining that these segments can sustain 25-30 per cent growth going forward.

Speaking during the company’s post-quarter analyst call, Sunil D’Souza, Managing Director and CEO, said growth businesses now ac-

count for 36 per cent of the India business after expanding 47 per cent year-on-year. “Our aspirations are at 25 to 30 per cent growth... 25 to 30 per cent should be the new normal going forward,” he said, adding that the company will continue investing in innovation, advertising and distribution to scale these businesses.

While reaffirming the company’s long-term outlook, D’Souza said TCPL expects to continue delivering double-digit overall revenue growth despite a high base. “We will drive double-digit growth. There will be those odd quarters where we will have mid-teens. There will be those quarters where it will be low double-digits,” he said, noting that the runway for the company’s growth businesses remains “as long as you can imagine.”

REVENUE RISES

The comments came after TCPL reported a 12 per cent year-on-year increase in consolidated revenue from operations to ₹5,349 crore for the June quarter, while net profit rose 29 per cent to ₹427 crore. India-branded business posted 13 per cent underlying volume growth,

while the international business grew 16 per cent on a reported basis.

D’Souza said the beverages business faced temporary headwinds during the quarter. “A minor issue of LPG shortages impacting small restaurants and street-side vendors, including tea shops in the South, did impact the business,” he said.

Overseas, an unusually warm June affected demand across key markets. “The US, the UK and Canada were impacted, especially in the month of June, by the unusually warm summer... Most specifically in the UK and in the black tea category,” he noted. However, coffee continued to perform strongly, growing 24 per cent, while the salt business delivered a robust performance despite calibrated price hikes taken during June.

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